



Prelims 2026

‘Ranbhoomi’ ALL INDIA MOCK TEST

Paper – I
**GENERAL STUDIES
AIMT – 3.0**

(Solutions & Explanations)

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1. Answer: A

Explanation:

- **Statement I is correct:** India follows a "positive secularism" (often termed *Sarva Dharma Sambhava* or equal respect for all religions), which allows state intervention to reform or support religious practices. This differs from the Western "negative" or "strict separation" model, which mandates a total separation between state and religion, treating it solely as a private matter.
- **Statement II is correct and Statement II explains Statement I :** The Indian State guarantees religious freedom under Articles 25-30 but maintains a "principled distance" rather than strict separation. The state may intervene in religious practices to uphold fundamental rights, ensure social reform, and prohibit discriminatory practices like untouchability (Article 17), balancing personal freedom with public order, morality, and health. For example, Hindu Code Bills (1950s), temple entry legislation, Sabarimala judgment (2018), and the prohibition of triple talaq (2019) all demonstrate the State's role in reforming religious practice in the interest of equality and dignity.

Subject: Polity || Preamble Values - Secular

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Key Constitutional Articles on Indian Secularism
 - Article 25: Freedom of conscience and free profession, practice and propagation of religion — subject to public order, morality, and health.
 - Article 26: Freedom to manage religious affairs — every religious denomination can manage its own affairs in matters of religion.
 - Article 27: No person shall be compelled to pay taxes for the promotion of any particular religion.
 - Article 28: No religious instruction in fully state-funded educational institutions.
- Landmark Supreme Court Cases on Secularism
 - Kesavananda Bharati v. State of Kerala (1973): Established secularism as part of the 'basic structure' of the Constitution — cannot be abrogated even by constitutional amendment.
 - S.R. Bommai v. Union of India (1994): Secularism declared a basic feature; religion cannot be mixed with State power; State must be neutral to all religions.
 - Indian Young Lawyers Association v. State of Kerala (Sabarimala, 2018): SC held that exclusion of women from temples was unconstitutional — State's constitutional morality overrides popular religious morality.

🔍 **Further reading:** S.R. Bommai Case (1994), Sabarimala Judgment (2018), Articles 25–28, Constitution of India, 42nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1976 (insertion of 'Secular' in Preamble)

2. Answer: C

Explanation:

- **C is correct :** The Preamble mentions “FRATERNITY assuring the dignity of the individual and the **unity and integrity** of the Nation”. Article 51A(c) mentions “to uphold and protect the sovereignty, **unity and integrity** of India”.
- DPSPs and Fundamental Rights do not mention the term “unity and integrity”.

Subject: Polity || Fundamental Duties

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- “Kartavyam” Initiative on Fundamental Duties
 - Launched by the Campus Law Centre, University of Delhi in collaboration with 21 universities and institutions
 - Aims to promote a duty-centric approach and develop duty jurisprudence within the framework of constitutional and legislative discourse
- Many Fundamental Duties have been reinforced through judicial interpretation rather than explicit laws, for example, the *M.C. Mehta* series of cases, where the courts interpreted article 51A(g) (mandating duty to protect the environment) as binding on state actions
- India has introduced many laws aimed at protecting national honour, preserving the environment, safeguarding cultural heritage, promoting gender dignity, advancing education, and protecting public property. Such as: - Environment Protection Act 1986 and the Biological Diversity Act, 2002; Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act, 1984, The Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 (Section 325 to 327); and Right to Education Act, 2009

🔍 **Further reading:** <https://bit.ly/41honhV>

3. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **I and II are correct :** Article 85(1) of the Constitution empowers the President to summon each House of Parliament to meet at such time and place as he thinks fit, but six months shall not intervene between its last sitting in one Session and the date appointed for its first sitting in the next Session. The President exercises the power to summon the Houses on the recommendation of the **Prime Minister** or the **Cabinet**.
- Source : Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs
<https://www.mpa.gov.in/sites/default/files/parlia3.pdf>

Subject: Polity | | Parliament Sessions

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Parliament Sessions
 - Based on a provision of the Government of India Act, 1935
 - Budget Session : Longest session. It starts towards the end of January, and concludes by the end of April or first week of May. The session has a recess so that Parliamentary Committees can discuss the budgetary proposals.
 - Monsoon Session : Second session (around three-week). Usually begins in July and finishes in August.
 - Winter Session : The parliamentary year ends with a three week-long Winter Session, which is held from November to December.
 - Secretary-General issues the summons to each member specifying the date and place for a session of the House

🔍 **Further reading:** Rules of Procedure and Conduct of Business in Parliament

4. Answer: D

Explanation:

- The Eighth Schedule to the Constitution of India lists the languages officially recognized by the Government of India. Originally containing 14 languages in 1950, as of 2024, 22 languages have been classified under the schedule. The Constitutional provisions relating to the Eighth Schedule occur in article 344(1) and 351 of the Constitution (Part XVII - Official Language).
- **I is not correct :** Official languages are declared under the Official Languages Act, 1963. This Act provides for the languages which may be used for the official purposes of the Union, for transaction of business in Parliament, for Central and State Acts and for certain purposes in High Courts.
- **II is correct :** The Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution promotes linguistic diversity by recognizing 22 major languages, providing them with official status, development resources, and cultural protection. It safeguards regional, tribal, and classical languages such as Santhali, Manipuri, and Sanskrit, ensuring their inclusion in education, administration, and digital platforms. Union Minister Shri G. Kishan Reddy recently emphasised that the Eighth Schedule included 14 languages, which has now expanded to 22, reflecting India's diversity.

Source : PIB

(<https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleaseIframePage.aspx?PRID=2085529®=3&lang=2>)

- **III is correct :** Article 344(1) provides for the constitution of a Commission by the President consisting of a Chairman and other members representing the different languages specified in the Eighth Schedule to make recommendations to the President for the progressive use of Hindi for official purposes of the Union. Article 351 of the Constitution provides that it shall be the duty of the Union to **promote the spread of the Hindi** language to develop it so that it may serve as a medium of expression for all the elements of the composite culture of India and to **secure its enrichment** by assimilating without interfering with its genius, the forms, style and expressions used in Hindustani and in the other **languages** of India **specified in the Eighth Schedule**, and by drawing, wherever necessary or desirable, for its vocabulary, primarily, on Sanskrit and secondarily on other languages. It would thus appear that the **Eighth Schedule was intended to promote the progressive use of Hindi and for its enrichment and promotion**.

Source : MHA

https://www.mha.gov.in/sites/default/files/EighthSchedule_19052017.pdf

Subject: Polity | | Eighth Schedule

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Eighth Schedule
 - 14 were originally included. Sindhi was added in 1967. Konkani, Manipuri and Nepali were included in 1992. Bodo, Dogri, Maithili and Santhali were added in 2004.
 - English is NOT included.
 - At present, there are demands for inclusion of 38 more languages in the Eighth Schedule.
 - Related committees : Pahwa (1996) and Sitakant Mohapatra (2003)
- Classical Languages
 - 11 languages presently recognized which boast rich, independent ancient literary traditions spanning over 1,500–2,000+ years.
 - Tamil, Sanskrit, Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, Odia, and the newly added (in 2024) Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese, and Bengal

🔍 **Further reading:** Classical languages

<https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2182753®=3&lang=2>

5. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The Representation of the People Act, 1951 provides for the conduct of elections to the Houses of Parliament and to the House(s) of the Legislature of each State, the qualifications and disqualifications for membership of those Houses, the corrupt practices and other offences related to such elections and the decision of doubts and disputes related to such elections.
- The Representation of the People Act, 1950 provides for the allocation of seats in, and the delimitation of constituencies for the purpose of election to, the House of the People and the Legislatures of States, the qualifications of voters at such elections, the preparation of electoral rolls, the manner of filling seats in the Council of States to be filled by representatives of Union territories, and matters connected therewith.
- **I is correct** : A person is a member of Schedule Caste in a particular State. He can contest election from any other State for Lok Sabha from a seat reserved for Scheduled Castes. (Refer : Sec. 4 of the RPA, 1951)
- **II is not correct** : A person is a member of a Schedule Tribe in a particular State. He can contest election from any other State for Lok Sabha from a seat reserved for Scheduled Tribes **except Lakshadweep**, other than those in **autonomous Districts of Assam** and excluding the **tribal areas of Assam**. (Refer: Sec. 4 of the RPA, 1951)
- **III is correct** : A person is a member of the Scheduled Castes or Scheduled Tribes community. He can contest an election from a general constituency. (Refer: Sec. 4 & 5 of the Representation of People Act, 1951)
- Source : MEA
https://www.mea.gov.in/Uploads/PublicationDocs/19169_Frequently_Asked_Questions_16-03-2009.pdf

Subject: Polity || Election Process

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Election Process
 - A person who is an elector in a particular State **cannot** contest election for a seat in the Legislative Assembly of any other State. (Sec. 5 of the RPA, 1951)
 - A person who is convicted for some offence and is sentenced to imprisonment for 2 years **cannot** contest elections. Even if he/she is on bail, after the conviction and appeal is pending for disposal, he/she is disqualified from contesting an election as per Supreme Court's decision. But if the **conviction is also stayed, then he/she can contest**. (Sec. 8(3) of RPA, 1951)
 - A person **confined in Jail cannot** vote in an election, whether under a sentence of imprisonment or transportation or otherwise, or is in the lawful custody of the police. (Sec. 62(5) of the RPA, 1951)
 - A person subjected to **preventive detention** under any law **can vote** in an election by Postal Ballot paper. (Sec. 62(5) of the RPA, 1951 and Rule 18(a)(iv) of Conduct of Elections Rules 1961).

🔍 **Further reading:** RPA 1951 and RPA 1950

6. Answer: A

Explanation:

- A no-confidence motion (Rule 198 of the Rules of Procedure and Conduct of Business in Lok Sabha) is an attempt, usually by an Opposition party, to get the government of the day to prove its majority on the floor of the House. The motion can only be moved by a member in the Lok Sabha, and, once moved, it offers MP's an opportunity to discuss the government's performance, before voting on whether the ruling party has the "confidence" of the House.

- A no-confidence motion is different from a motion of confidence, or trust vote, which is moved by the government, as an ordinary motion under Rule 184. A government can prove its majority by moving a confidence motion as a counter to the opposition parties.
- **I is not correct** : A motion of no-confidence is moved with the support of at least 50 members, as per Rule 198.
- **II is correct** : If a no-confidence motion is supported by a minimum of 50 members in the Lok Sabha, the Speaker is bound to grant leave for discussion in the House, acting under Rule 198. Once admitted, the debate must take place within 10 days.
- **III is not correct** : The first no-confidence motion that led to the falling of a government was moved by YB Chavan in 1979 against the government of Prime Minister Morarji Desai. After a nine-hour debate spread over two days, Desai resigned before the motion could be put to vote. So far, 28 no-confidence motions (the last one being introduced in 2023 in the 17th Lok Sabha) and 11 confidence motions have been discussed. 27 out of 28 no-confidence motions (excluding the one being discussed today) have been voted upon and rejected. This means that **no government has ever had to resign following a vote of no-confidence** (no-confidence motion of 1979 was not voted upon).
- Source : PRS and Rules of Procedure and Conduct of Business in Lok Sabha
<https://prsindia.org/theprsblog/first-no-confidence-motion-of-the-17th-lok-sabha-discussed-today>

Subject: Polity || No-Confidence Motion

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- No-Confidence Motion
 - 50% of all no-confidence motions (14 out of 28) were discussed between 1965 and 1975. Of these, 12 were against governments headed by Indira Gandhi.
 - The first no-confidence motion, brought in 1979 to demonstrate confidence in Charan Singh's government, was not discussed at all. The PM resigned before the discussion could take place

Further reading: Confidence Motions

7. Answer: D

Explanation:

- Article 145(3) of the Constitution provides that the minimum number of Judges (which means the "quorum") in the Supreme Court who are to sit for the purpose of deciding any case involving a substantial question of law as to the interpretation of this Constitution or for the purpose of hearing any reference under Article 143 (Power of President to consult Supreme Court) shall be five. So **A = 5** and **C = 5**.
- Order XXXVIII of the Supreme Court Rules, 2013 deals with applications for enforcement of fundamental rights under Article 32. Rule (1) of Order XXXVIII provides that every petition under article 32 of the Constitution which raises a substantial question of law as to the interpretation of the Constitution shall be heard by a Division Court of **not less than five Judges**. So **B = 5**.

Source : Supreme Court Rules, 2013

<https://cdnbbsr.s3waas.gov.in/s3ec0490f1f4972d133619a60c30f3559e/uploads/2024/01/2024011691-1.pdf>

- So, **A + B + C = 5+5+5 = 15**.

Subject: Polity || Supreme Court

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Lack of Quorum: If a quorum is unavailable, the Chief Justice of India can, with the President's consent, appoint a High Court judge as an ad hoc judge (Article 127).
- Ad Hoc Judges: Ad hoc judges under Article 127 have the same powers and duties as permanent Supreme Court judges during their tenure.
- A constitutional bench can be formed if the President seeks the opinion of the Supreme Court on a question of law or fact under Article 143 of the Constitution.
- The Constitution does not mandate a fixed number of judges for a Constitution Bench at the High Court level.
- Petitions under article 32 which do not raise a substantial question of law as to the interpretation of the Constitution may be heard and decided by a Division Court of less than five Judges in the Supreme Court.
- All interlocutory and miscellaneous applications connected with a petition under article 32 of the Constitution, may be heard and decided by a Division Court of less than five Judges in the Supreme Court.

Further reading: Supreme Court Rules 2013, Advocate-on-Record in Supreme Court

8. Answer: C

Explanation:

- As per Article 317(3) of the Constitution, the President may by order remove from office the Chairman or any other member of a Public Service Commission if the Chairman or such other member is, in the opinion of the President, unfit to continue in office by reason of **infirmity of mind or body**.
- CAG (Article 148) : Can only be removed from office in like manner and on the like grounds as a Judge of the Supreme Court (given below).
- Supreme Court Judge (Article 124(4)) : Can only be removed by an order of the President passed after an address by each House of Parliament supported by a majority of the total membership of that House and by a majority of not less than two-thirds of the members of that House present and voting has been presented to the President in the same session for such removal on the ground of proved misbehaviour or incapacity.
- Chief Election Commissioner (Article 324(5)) : Can only be removed from office in like manner and on the like grounds as a Judge of the Supreme Court.

Subject: Polity || UPSC, Removal of Judges

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968 : Regulates the procedure for the investigation and proof of the misbehaviour or incapacity of a judge of the Supreme Court or of a High Court.
 - Committee for investigation into the grounds of the removal of a Judge : Chief Justice or any other Judge of the Supreme Court + One of the Chief Justices of the High Courts + A distinguished jurist (in the opinion of Speaker/Chairman)
 - If Committee finds the judge not guilty, the motion of removal is dropped
 - If Committee finds the judge guilty, the motion is put to vote in the Parliament (or State Legislature) and an address praying for the removal of the Judge shall be presented to the President by the Parliament in the same session in which the motion has been adopted

🔗 **Further reading:** Judges (Protection) Act, 1985

9. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Quasi-judicial refers to a proceeding conducted by an administrative or executive official or organization that is similar to a court proceeding, e.g. a hearing conducted by a human rights commission.
- **I is correct** : The Chairman of the Rajya Sabha acts as a quasi-judicial authority when deciding on the disqualification of members under the Tenth Schedule (anti-defection law). While primarily a parliamentary presiding officer, this role requires interpreting laws and adjudicating disputes.
- **II is correct** : The Finance Commission of India is a quasi-judicial body because it has the powers of a Civil Court under the Code of Civil Procedure 1908 to call witnesses, ask for production of public documents, and require information from any court or office Sec. 8 of the Finance Commission (Miscellaneous Provisions) Act, 1951).
- **III is correct** : The State (and Central) Information Commission is a quasi-judicial authority as it has the powers vested in a civil court while trying a suit under the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908 such as summoning and enforcing the attendance of persons and compel them to give oral or written evidence on oath and to produce the documents. (Sec. 18 of the Right to Information Act, 2005).

Subject: Polity || Quasi-Judicial Authorities

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Key Judicial and Quasi-Judicial Bodies
 - National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission handles consumer disputes.
 - Competition Commission of India ensures fair competition.
 - Income Tax Appellate Tribunal decides cases related to direct taxes.
 - Telecom Disputes Settlement & Appellate Tribunal adjudicates disputes in the telecom sector.
 - National Human Rights Commission investigates human rights violations.
 - Railway Claims Tribunal handles claims against railways.
 - Securities Appellate Tribunal handles SEBI appeals.
 - Central Administrative Tribunal settles disputes regarding recruitment/service conditions of public servants.
 - National Green Tribunal for environmental disputes.

🔗 **Further reading:** Tribunals

10. Answer: D

Explanation:

- **I is not correct :** As per Sec. 2 of the Salary and Allowances of Leaders of Opposition in Parliament Act, 1977, the LoP is the leader of the opposition party having the greatest numerical strength and recognised as such by the Speaker/Chairman. The **Act does not mention** that a political party must secure at least 10% of the total seats in the Lok Sabha to have their leader formally recognized as the LoP. The 10% Rule has been by practice a requirement to lay claim to the post, as evidenced by the fact that the post in Lok Sabha was vacant from 2014-2024 because no party secured 10% (one-tenth) of the total strength of the Lok Sabha. The Institute of Secretariat Training and Management (managed by the Department of Personnel and Training) mentioned in one of its booklets that the recognition of the Leader of Opposition is given by the Speaker of the Lok Sabha – “provided the largest party in opposition have minimum 55 MP in the House”. Source : https://www.istm.gov.in/uploads/tenders/17037622321674040155Parliamentary_Procedure.pdf
- **II is not correct :** As per Sec. 2 of the Salary and Allowances of Leaders of Opposition in Parliament Act, when two or more opposition parties have the same number of seats in the Lok Sabha/Rajya Sabha, the Speaker/Chairman shall, having regard to the status of the parties, recognise any one of the Leaders of such parties as the Leader of the Opposition for the purposes of this section and such recognition shall be final and conclusive.
- **III is not correct :** The Salary and Allowances of Leaders of Opposition in Parliament Act, 1977 regulates the salary and allowances of the LoP. His salary and allowances (equivalent to a Cabinet Minister as per the Act) can be varied to his disadvantage after his appointment through an amendment of the Act. There is no provision in the Act preventing their salary from being varied to their disadvantage after appointment, unlike provisions for constitutional authorities like Supreme Court judges or the CAG.

Subject: Polity || Leader of Opposition

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Leader of the House
 - Prime Minister is the Leader of the House in Lok Sabha, if he/she is a member of the House, otherwise a Minister (Minister of Parliamentary Affairs) nominated by the PM who is a Member of Lok Sabha will be the Leader of the House in Lok Sabha.
 - In Rajya Sabha, PM will be Leader of the House, if he is a member of the House and if not, leader is appointed by the P.M. from amongst the Members of his Cabinet.
 - The leader of the House is responsible for the arrangement of the Govt. business in the House.

🔗 **Further reading:** Shadow Cabinet

11. Answer: A

Explanation:

- In India, judicial review is the power of the Supreme Court or High Courts to determine whether a law or decision made by the executive, legislative, or administrative branches of government complies with constitutional principles. The Supreme Court or High Courts reserve the authority to declare it void if it is found to be unlawful. It upholds the rule of law, protects fundamental rights, and maintains the separation of powers, acting as a cornerstone of Indian democracy.

Subject: Polity || Judicial Review

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Types of Judicial Review in India
 - Constitutional Amendments : Whether the legislature's proposed constitutional amendments contradict the fundamental framework or any other clauses.
 - Executive Actions : Examining the government's executive branch's operations. Involves constitutionality of administrative authorities' rulings, policies, and directives, and evaluating the legality.
 - Legislation : Legislations passed by the legislature are examined to make sure they comply with the Constitution.

🔗 **Further reading:** Basic Structure of Constitution

12. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **I is not correct :** As per Paragraph 3 of the Sixth Schedule, Autonomous District Councils can make laws on the subjects of land, forest management (other than reserved forests), shifting cultivation, village administration, inheritance of property, marriage and social customs. However, these laws require the **assent of the Governor** of the state, not the President.
- **II is correct :** As per Paragraph 16 of the Sixth Schedule, ADCs can be dissolved by the Governor on the recommendation of the Commission appointed by him (under Paragraph 14) to inquire into and report on the administration of autonomous districts and autonomous regions.
- **III is correct :** As per Paragraph 2 of the Sixth Schedule, ADCs consist of not more than thirty members, of whom not more than four persons shall be **nominated by the Governor** and the **rest shall be elected** on the basis of adult suffrage.

Subject: Polity || Sixth Schedule

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Sixth Schedule (Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Mizoram)
 - Governor can create new autonomous districts, change the areas and boundaries of autonomous districts (on recommendation of the Commission constituted under Paragraph 14 of the Sixth Schedule)
 - Elected members of District Councils hold office for five years, while nominated members hold office at the pleasure of the Governor
 - During Emergency (Article 352), the term of office of elected members may be extended by the Governor by upto one year at a time

🔍 **Further reading:** Fifth Schedule

13. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Article 81 (Composition of the House of the People) of the Constitution provides for the “one person, one vote, one value” principle (and Article 170 – Composition of the Legislative Assemblies) which state that the **population ratio** for the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assembly constituencies shall be the **same as far as practicable**.
- Article 81(2)(a) says, “There shall be allotted to each State a number of seats in the House of the People in such manner that the ratio between that number and the population of the state is, so far as practicable, the same for all States.” This seeks to ensure equal political weight per citizen across states — a voter in Tamil Nadu should carry roughly the same weight as a voter in Uttar Pradesh and upholds the democratic principle of “one person, one vote, one value.” It prevents smaller states from being over-represented or larger states from being under-represented in Parliament.
- Article 81 (2) (b) says, “Each State shall be divided into territorial constituencies in such manner that the ratio between the population of each constituency and number of seats allotted to it is, so far as practicable, the same throughout the State.”
- Source : Indian Express
<https://indianexpress.com/article/political-pulse/womens-quota-why-govt-run-into-hurdles-expand-lok-sabha-same-states-heft-10600104/>

Subject: Polity || Delimitation and Fair Representation

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Delimitation of Constituencies :
 - Delimitation Commissions (DCs) have been constituted 4 times under the Delimitation Commission Act, 1952; Delimitation Commission Act, 1962; Delimitation Act, 1972 and Delimitation Act, 2002
 - Order of DCs have the force of law and cannot be called in question before any court. They are laid before Lok Sabha and the State Legislative Assembly concerned, but they cannot modify DC's orders.
- A.P. SC Welfare Association v. UoI (2004) :
 - It dealt with challenges to the 84th Constitutional Amendment Act, 2001, which froze constituency delimitation until 2026.
 - Supreme Court dismissed the PIL, finding no violation of constitutional rights in postponing delimitation based on 1991, rather than 2001, census figures.

🔍 **Further reading:** Constitutional Provisions (Art. 81, 82, 170, 330, 331, 332, 333)

14. Answer: D

Explanation:

- **I is not correct :** The Model Code of Conduct (MCC) is **not** a statutory document. It is **not part** of the Representation of the People Act, 1951. It is a non-statutory set of guidelines issued by the Election Commission of India to regulate political parties and candidates prior to elections, to ensure free and fair elections. This is in keeping with Article 324 of the Constitution, which gives the Election Commission the power to supervise elections to the Parliament and state legislatures.
- **II is not correct :** The MCC is valid from the date of announcement of the election schedule by the Election Commission of India **till the date that results are announced**.
- **III is not correct :** The MCC is **applicable to election manifestos** of political parties. The MCC directs that while releasing election manifestos for any election to the Parliament or State Legislatures, the Political Parties shall adhere to the following guidelines :
 - Election manifestos must not contradict the ideals and principles of the Constitution, and must be consistent with the letter and spirit of the MCC
 - In line with DPSPs, parties may promise welfare measures, but must avoid promises that could compromise electoral purity or unduly influence voters.
 - To ensure credibility and a level playing field, manifestos should include the rationale behind promises and broadly indicate their financial feasibility. Voters' trust must only be sought on promises that are realistically fulfillable.

Subject: Polity || Model Code of Conduct

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- MCC
 - A form of the MCC was first introduced in the state assembly elections in Kerala in 1960
 - In the 1962 general elections to the Lok Sabha, the MCC was circulated to recognised parties, and state governments sought feedback from the parties.
 - In 1979, the Election Commission added a section to regulate the 'party in power' and prevent it from gaining an unfair advantage at the time of elections.
 - In 2013, the Supreme Court directed the Election Commission to include guidelines regarding election manifestos, which it had included in the MCC for the 2014 general elections.
 - In 2015, the Law Commission noted that the MCC prohibits the issue of advertisement at the cost of public exchequer during the election period.

🔗 **Further reading:** <http://bit.ly/4vwVaNQ>

15. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **I is correct :** In India, the President is a constitutional head who must act according to the "aid and advice" of the Council of Ministers (Article 74). The Supreme Court confirmed in *Maru Ram v. Union of India* that the power to pardon under Article 72 (President) (and Article 161 - Governor) of the Constitution can be exercised by the Central and the State Governments, not by the President or Governors on their own. In contrast, the US President exercises this as a personal prerogative without needing approval from the Cabinet or Congress.
Source : Indian Kanoon <https://indiankanoon.org/doc/1222748/>
- **II is not correct :** In the USA, the President's power is strictly limited to federal offenses. In the USA, the crimes committed against State laws are pardoned by the respective State Governors. In India, while the President primarily deals with Union laws, his power is actually broader in one specific sense : he is the sole authority to pardon a death sentence, even if that sentence was passed under a State law.
- **III is correct :** The US Supreme Court ruled that the President can pardon criminal contempt of court. In India, the power under Article 72 does not extend to contempt of court, as it is seen as an inherent power of the judiciary to maintain its own dignity.

Subject: Polity || Pardoning Power

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Pardoning Power of the President and Governor
 - President has the power to pardon or reduce the sentence of a person convicted by a military court
 - Governor can only exercise pardoning powers in relation to convictions under state laws and cannot interfere with military court sentences or federal crimes

- Landmark Judgements :
 - KM Nanavati vs. State of Bombay: SC held that the Governor's power to suspend a sentence under Article 161 is subject to the rules made by the Supreme Court under Article 145. This means that the Governor cannot suspend a sentence if the matter is subjudice before the Supreme Court
 - E. Sudhakar vs. Govt of Andhra Pradesh: The Supreme Court held that the pardoning power of the President and the Governors is subject to judicial review

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://bit.ly/3PSNjtC>

16. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The responsibility of collecting monthly rural retail prices for the Consumer Price Index Numbers for Agricultural Labourers (CPI-AL) and Rural Labourers (CPI-RL) lies with the Field Operations Division (FOD) of the National Statistical Office, part of the Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation (MoSPI). On the basis of this data, the Labour Bureau, under the Ministry of Labour & Employment releases the CPI-AL and CPI-RL. They are released on a monthly basis, with a lag of 20 days, ensuring timely and policy-relevant information for indexation and other socio-economic analysis.
- Source : Labour Bureau
<https://labourbureau.gov.in/consumer-price-index-numbers-for-agricultural-and-rural-labourers>

Subject: Economy || CPI

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- CPI-AL and CPI-RL
 - In June 2025, the base year was revised to 2019=100 (previous base year 1986-87)
 - Price data is now collected from 787 representative sample villages, up from 600 villages earlier, ensuring broader and more inclusive representation.
 - The number of items in the consumption basket has increased to approximately 150–200 per State, as against 65–106 in the old series.
 - The index compilation method has shifted from the Arithmetic Mean (AM) to the Geometric Mean (GM), aligning with international standards.
 - The revised indices follow the latest Classification of Individual Consumption According to Purpose (COICOP) – 2018, enabling international comparability.

🔗 **Further reading:** CPI 2024 Series <https://bit.ly/4dFXjQR>

17. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Strategic disinvestment involves the sale of a substantial portion of government shares in a public sector enterprise (often more than 50%), resulting in a transfer of management control to the acquiring entity. This is different from simply selling minority stakes, which does not involve transferring control. In Disinvestment, the government may sell its stakes (reduce its ownership) in a PSU/company to a buyer but the government may still retain its majority and management control. It may be done through listing of the PSU on the stock market (Initial Public Offering) or direct sale. In the Strategic sale of a company, the transaction has two elements :
 - Transfer of a block of shares to a strategic partner, and
 - Transfer of management control to the strategic partner

Subject: Economy || Disinvestment

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Process of strategic disinvestment in India
 1. NITI Aayog identifies the PSUs that can be considered for strategic disinvestment and forwards its recommendations to DIPAM
 2. DIPAM examines these recommendations, formulates a proposal, and forwards it to the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) for approval
 3. Once the CCEA approves the disinvestment, DIPAM initiates the process, which includes valuation, inviting bids, and selecting the strategic buyer

🔗 **Further reading:** DIPAM <https://bit.ly/41U3Sba>

18. Answer: D

Explanation:

- Off-budget borrowings are borrowings made by entities other than the central government to fund government expenditure, but which do not appear in the Union Budget's fiscal deficit calculations, even though the government bears the ultimate liability.
- **I is correct** : The government, instead of directly paying food subsidies, if it gets FCI to borrow from the market, this liability doesn't show in the fiscal deficit. It is an example of off-budget borrowing.
- **II is correct** : NHAI borrows from markets to build highways on the government's behalf. The debt is on NHAI's books, not the government's, keeping the fiscal deficit low. It is an example of off-budget borrowing.
- **III is correct** : SPVs are created precisely to raise funds off the government's balance sheet. The government bears implicit/explicit liability, but the borrowing stays outside the budget. It is an example of off-budget borrowing.
- **IV is correct** : NSSF funds are mobilised from the public (small savings schemes) and routed to fund government expenditure without being reflected as direct government borrowing in the budget. It is an example of off-budget borrowing.

Subject: Economy || Off-Budget Borrowings

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Status of off-budget borrowings in India

(a) Total amount of off-budget borrowings undertaken by Central Government and State Governments in last 5 years is as follows:

	(₹ in crore)				
	2020-21	2021-22	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25
Total off-budget borrowing undertaken through issue of Government fully serviced bonds and NSSF loans by the Central Government	1,21,301.10 [#]	751.80 [*]	NIL	NIL	NIL
Total Off Budget Borrowings of States	-- [@]	67,181.27	35,772.91	21,250.75	29,335.61

- The Central Government is transparently disclosing off-budget borrowing undertaken, through Budget documents and the Central Government has discontinued off-budget borrowing from FY 2022-23
- As per the provisions of the FRBM Act, 2003, outstanding amount of off-budget borrowing is counted in Central Government debt
- In order to curb the off-budget borrowing and bring fiscal discipline among States, with effect from FY 2021-22, borrowings made by 'State owned entities', where principal and/or interest is serviced through State Budgets and/or assignment of taxes/cess or any other State's revenue, are factored in for the purpose of issuance of borrowing consent to State Governments under Article 293(3) of the Constitution

Further reading: FRBM Act, 2003

19. Answer: B

Explanation:

- When the rupee loses value against foreign currencies (e.g., ₹80 → ₹85 per dollar), it means you need more rupees to buy the same amount of foreign currency. So, imports become costlier, exports become cheaper. Core concept :
 - If you earn/receive in foreign currency – you benefit (get more rupees)
 - If you spend/pay in foreign currency – you lose (pay more rupees)
- **I is correct** : Indian companies with foreign currency denominated loans borrow in dollars/euros but earn in rupees. Depreciation means they must arrange more rupees to repay the same loan amount, increasing their debt burden and interest costs significantly. Negatively impacted.
- **II is not correct** : Indian IT firms exporting software services to the USA bill their clients in dollars. When the rupee depreciates, the same dollar revenue converts to more rupees, directly boosting their profit margins. Positively impacted.
- **III is correct** : Indian pilgrims travelling abroad for religious purposes (like Mecca or Jerusalem) have to spend in foreign currency abroad. A weaker rupee means they must spend more rupees to arrange the same foreign currency, making the trip costlier for them. Negatively impacted.
- **IV is not correct** : Domestic manufacturers competing with imported goods will benefit because depreciation makes imported goods more expensive in rupee terms. This naturally shifts consumer preference toward domestically produced goods, giving local manufacturers a competitive pricing advantage in their own market. Positively impacted.

Subject: Economy || Rupee Depreciation

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Role of exchange rates on India's trade competitiveness
 - NER (Nominal Exchange Rate)
 - NER = Number of units of the domestic currency that are needed to purchase a unit of a given foreign currency.
 - Example : If Rupee depreciates from ₹80 to ₹85 per dollar. An Indian textile exporter selling shirts at \$10 now receives ₹850 instead of ₹800, making exports nominally more competitive.
 - If Indian inflation is simultaneously high (say 8% vs USA's 2%), the cost of producing those shirts also rises, eroding the apparent gain. This is why NER alone is a misleading indicator of competitiveness.
 - RER (Real Exchange Rate)
 - $RER = NER \times (\text{Foreign Price Level} / \text{Domestic Price Level})$
 - Example : If Rupee depreciates 5%, then for exporters, the same dollar fetched more rupees. But if India's inflation is 7% vs USA's 2%, domestic production costs rise faster, eroding the export advantage. The RER may thus actually appreciate, making exports less competitive despite the nominal depreciation.
 - REER (Real Effective Exchange Rate) : India trades with the USA, EU, China, UAE, and UK. REER takes a weighted average of India's real exchange rate against all these partners based on trade volume.
 - Scenario 1 : REER Appreciates (rises above 100): Rupee strengthens in real terms against the basket. Indian software, pharma, and textiles become costlier for all major partners simultaneously. Export growth slows; import substitution weakens and trade deficit widens
 - Scenario 2 : REER Depreciates (falls below 100): India's goods become cheaper across all major markets at once. Boosts export competitiveness in the US, EU, and Gulf simultaneously. Helps sectors like IT services, gems & jewellery, engineering goods

 **Further reading:** Trade Competitiveness

20. Answer: A

Explanation:

- The Budget Division of the Department of Economic Affairs under the Ministry of Finance is responsible for preparation of and submission to Parliament, Annual Budget as well as Supplementary and Excess Demands for Grants of the Central Government and of States and UTs under President's Rule. It also handles Guarantees given by Government of India.
- It handles the work relating to administration of the Contingency Fund of India.
- It also deals with issues relating to Public Debt and Market Loans of the Central Government. It plays an important role in public debt management through planning borrowing of GoI, formulating debt management strategy, cash monitoring and management, increased interaction with market participants etc.
- It handles the release of States' share of Central Taxes and duties to State Governments as per approved recommendations of the Finance Commission.
- It also handles the issues pertaining to administration of National Savings Institute (NSI) and Small Savings Schemes, and the work relating to preparation of new schemes, amendments in existing schemes, discontinuation/rationalisation of small savings schemes.
- It is also responsible for administration of the FRBM Act, 2003.

Subject: Economy | | Department of Economic Affairs

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Department of Expenditure (Ministry of Finance)
 - Nodal Department for overseeing the public financial management system in the Central Government and matters connected with state finances
 - Responsible for the implementation of the recommendations of the Central Pay Commission, monitoring of audit comments/ observations, preparation of Central Government Accounts

 **Further reading:** <https://bit.ly/4meLrau>

21. Answer: D

Explanation:

- **I, II, III and IV are correct** : Liquidity Adjustment Facility refers to the Reserve Bank's operations through which it injects/absorbs liquidity into/from the banking system. It consists of overnight as well as term repo/reverse repos (fixed as well as variable rates), SDF and MSF. Apart from **LAF**, instruments of liquidity management include outright **open market operations** (OMOs), **forex swaps** and **market stabilisation scheme** (MSS).

Source : RBI Monetary Policy

https://www.rbi.org.in/scripts/fs_overview.aspx?fn=2752

- **Open Market Operations (OMOs)** : These include outright purchase/sale of government securities by the Reserve Bank for injection/absorption of durable liquidity in the banking system.
- **Market Stabilisation Scheme (MSS)** : Introduced in 2004. It is a monetary tool used by the RBI to manage excess liquidity in the banking system. It works by selling government securities (MSS Bonds) to absorb surplus funds, usually caused by large foreign capital inflows.
- **Forex Swaps** : It is used to inject or withdraw rupee liquidity without causing long-term volatility in foreign exchange reserves or bond markets. Recently, RBI infused 3 trillion rupees liquidity in the banking system through OMOs and forex swap.

Source : <https://bit.ly/4t9qxwb>

Subject: Economy || Monetary Policy

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Under the RBI Act, 1934, the RBI is entrusted with the responsibility of conducting monetary policy in India with the primary objective of **maintaining price stability** while **keeping in mind the objective of growth**.
- Under Section 45ZA, the Central Government, in consultation with the RBI, determines the inflation target in terms of the Consumer Price Index (CPI), once in five years and notifies it in the Official Gazette.
- In March 2026, the Central Government retained the inflation target (4 percent) and the tolerance band (upper tolerance limit of 6 percent and the lower tolerance limit of 2 percent) for the next 5-year period – April 1, 2026 to March 31, 2031.
- Section 45ZB of the RBI Act provides for the constitution of a six-member Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) to determine the policy rate required to achieve the inflation target.

🔍 **Further reading:** RBI Act, 1934

22. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Fiscal deficit is the difference between the total expenditure and total receipts (excluding borrowings) of the government. It represents the total amount the government needs to borrow to meet its expenses. A high and persistent fiscal deficit signals that the government is consistently spending far beyond its means, which has several macroeconomic consequences such as inflation.
 - Revenue Deficit = Revenue expenditure exceeds revenue receipts (day-to-day spending shortfall)
 - Fiscal Deficit = Total expenditure exceeds total receipts excluding borrowings (overall borrowing requirement)
- **I is correct** : When the government runs a high fiscal deficit, it borrows heavily from the market by issuing bonds and securities. This absorbs a large share of available savings, leaving less capital for private businesses to borrow and invest. As private investment falls, productive capacity and supply of goods shrinks. However, government spending (on salaries, pensions, subsidies, and welfare schemes – puts more money directly into the hands of people which raises consumption and demand) keeps aggregate demand elevated. This demand-supply mismatch creates upward pressure on prices which triggers inflation. This is known as the crowding out effect.
- **II is correct** : When the government borrows to finance its deficit, it pumps money into the economy through revenue expenditure on salaries, subsidies and welfare schemes. This raises aggregate demand across the economy. However, since this spending is not backed by a corresponding rise in productive capacity or output (capital expenditure), the excess demand over supply creates upward pressure on prices, fuelling inflation (a demand-pull inflation).

Subject: Economy || Fiscal Deficit

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- When the government spends on capital infrastructure, it does both simultaneously:
 - Raises aggregate demand in the short run (through contractor payments, employment, multiplier effect)
 - Raises productive capacity in the long run (better roads → lower logistics costs → more output → more supply)
 - This means capital spending can be non-inflationary or even deflationary in the long run because the supply side of the economy catches up with or exceeds the demand created.
 - Example: Building a highway raises demand for cement and steel in the short run. But once built, it reduces transportation costs, improves market access, and boosts agricultural and industrial output — expanding supply and potentially bringing prices down.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://bit.ly/41QdALI>

23. Answer: D

Explanation:

- Gross Domestic Savings is the portion of a country's GDP that is not consumed but set aside for future investment. It is calculated as: $GDS = GDP - \text{Total Consumption Expenditure}$
- It has three components:
 - Household savings
 - Private corporate savings
 - Public savings (government revenue surplus)
 So, GDS depends on the combined movement of all three sectors : household, corporate, and government.
- **I is not correct :** Household savings is only one component of GDS. Even if household financial savings rise, if private corporate savings or government savings fall simultaneously by a larger amount, overall GDS can still decline. For example, a rise in household savings accompanied by a large government fiscal deficit (dissaving) can result in net GDS falling
- **II is not correct :** A rise in GDP does not automatically mean a rise in savings. If the increase in GDP is entirely driven by a rise in consumption, savings may remain unchanged or even fall. For instance, if GDP grows because people are borrowing more to consume more, the consumption rise offsets the income rise and GDS does not necessarily increase. Savings depends on what portion of extra income is consumed, not just on income alone.
- **III is not correct :** A government revenue surplus contributes to public savings, which is one component of GDS. However, if this surplus is achieved by cutting government expenditure that previously supported private incomes, it could reduce household and corporate savings by a larger magnitude, causing overall GDS to fall. The components of GDS can move in offsetting directions, so no single component guarantees a rise in total GDS.

Subject: Economy || Savings

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Gross Domestic Savings (GDS) in India
 - India's GDS rate has experienced a structural decline over the past decade, dropping from 34.6% of GDP in 2011–12 to around 29.7% in 2022–23
 - Rising aspirational consumption among the middle class : easy availability of consumer credit and EMI culture encouraging borrowing to consume
 - Persistent revenue deficits mean the government is consuming more than it earns
 - Within financial assets, bank deposits have dropped significantly, while investments in equities/mutual funds saw a massive spike in growth, indicating a shift in risk appetite
 - Weak private investment cycle post-2012

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://bit.ly/4cvL4oF>

24. Answer: D

Explanation:

- Financial Inclusion means ensuring that all individuals and businesses, especially the poor, marginalised, and unbanked, have access to affordable, useful, and timely financial products and services such as savings, credit, insurance, and payments. Digital Financial Inclusion extends this concept by leveraging technology such as mobile phones, internet, and digital payment infrastructure to deliver financial services to those excluded from the traditional banking system.

- **I is correct :** Extending UPI to rural and semi-urban areas enables people without traditional bank branches to make payments, receive transfers, and conduct commerce digitally. It removes the barrier of physical distance from banking infrastructure, a major driver of financial exclusion in India. With feature phone-based UPI (UPI 123Pay) and offline UPI, even those without smartphones can transact digitally.
- **II is correct :** DBT ensures government welfare payments such as subsidies, scholarships, pensions, MGNREGA wages are transferred directly into the bank accounts of beneficiaries, eliminating middlemen and leakages. This serves financial inclusion in two ways: it leads beneficiaries to open bank accounts to receive transfers, and it familiarises them with formal banking.
- **III is correct :** BCs are bank representatives who operate in remote, unbanked villages using handheld devices and biometric authentication to provide basic banking services such as account opening, deposits, withdrawals, and loan applications. They are the last-mile connection between formal banks and the unbanked population, making financial inclusion physically accessible where no bank branch exists.
- **IV is correct :** Access to digital financial services is meaningless without the ability to use them safely and confidently. Digital literacy training equips marginalised communities such as women, elderly, tribal populations with the skills to use mobile banking, avoid fraud, and navigate digital payment platforms. Without this, technology-driven financial inclusion remains supply-side only, failing to generate actual usage and adoption.

Subject: Economy | | Financial Inclusion

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- **Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY)**
 - Flagship Scheme : PMJDY is the world's largest financial inclusion initiative.
 - Zero balance savings account with RuPay debit card
 - ₹2 lakh accident insurance and ₹30,000 life insurance cover
 - Overdraft facility of up to ₹10,000 for active account holders
 - Over 53 crore accounts opened as of 2024 with deposits exceeding ₹2 lakh crore
 - Critical issue is dormant accounts: A significant share of Jan Dhan accounts remain dormant or zero-balance, highlighting the gap between account opening (access) and actual usage (inclusion). True financial inclusion requires active usage, not just account ownership.
- **JAM Trinity : Jan Dhan + Aadhaar + Mobile = JAM Trinity**
 - This three-pillar architecture is the backbone of India's digital financial inclusion:
 - Jan Dhan provides the bank account
 - Aadhaar provides the unique digital identity for KYC
 - Mobile provides the delivery channel for services and transfers

Further reading: National Strategy for Financial Inclusion

25. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The Balance of Payments is a systematic record of all economic transactions between residents of a country and the rest of the world during a given period. It has two main accounts:
 - Current Account records flows of goods, services, income, and transfers (transactions that affect national income).
 - Capital Account records flows of financial assets and liabilities – borrowings, investments, and debt (transactions that affect national wealth/ownership).
- **I is correct :** Trade in Goods (Merchandise Trade) is the largest and most visible component of the current account. It records all physical exports and imports. The difference between merchandise exports and imports gives the trade balance. India consistently runs a merchandise trade deficit – importing more goods (especially oil and gold) than it exports.
- **II is not correct :** FDI involves a foreign entity acquiring a lasting interest and significant control (10%+ ownership) in a domestic enterprise. Since it represents a cross-border transfer of ownership and financial assets, it belongs to the **capital account**.
- **III is correct :** Services trade includes IT/software exports, tourism, financial services, education, and transport. India is a major services exporter, particularly in IT and business process outsourcing and consistently runs a services trade surplus, which partially offsets the merchandise trade deficit. It forms part of the current account's “invisibles” category.

- **IV is correct :** Income from investments abroad includes dividends, interest, and profits earned by Indian residents from their foreign investments, and vice versa. It is recorded in the current account under primary income. For example, dividends received by an Indian company from its foreign subsidiary.
- **V is not correct :** ECBs are loans raised by Indian companies from foreign lenders in foreign currency. Since they represent a cross-border debt obligation between residents and non-residents, they are recorded in the **capital/financial account**.
- **VI is correct :** Remittances are one-way transfers of money, typically sent by Indian workers abroad to their families in India. Since nothing is given in return, they are classified as unilateral transfers under the current account. India is consistently the world's largest recipient of remittances (a record USD 135.4 billion in FY25, marking a 14% year-on-year increase).

Subject: Economy || Balance of Payments

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- India's BoP
 - Current Account : Goods & Services + Primary Income + Secondary Income
 - Capital Account : Gross acquisitions /disposals of non-produced nonfinancial assets + Capital transfers
 - Financial Account : Direct Investment + Portfolio Investment + Financial derivatives (other than reserves) and employee stock options + Other investment (ADR/GDR + Currency & Deposits + Loans + Schemes + SDR + Reserve Assets)

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://bit.ly/41llEnG>

26. Answer: B

Explanation:

- A Non-Tariff Barrier is any trade restriction other than a customs duty or tariff that limits the free flow of goods and services between countries. While tariffs work through price mechanisms (making imports costlier), NTBs work through regulatory, administrative, or quantitative mechanisms that restrict trade volumes, access, or competitiveness. NTBs are increasingly used by countries because they are less transparent and harder to challenge under WTO rules than straightforward tariffs, making them a preferred tool of disguised protectionism.
- **A is not correct :** Import licensing requires foreign suppliers to obtain government permission before their goods can enter the domestic market. When applied across all categories, it creates bureaucratic delays, uncertainty, and costs that effectively restrict trade without any explicit tariff. It is an NTB.
- **B is correct :** Anti-dumping duties are technically tariffs. They are price-based measures imposed when foreign goods are sold below their normal value (cost of production or home market price) to gain unfair market share. They work through the price/tariff mechanism, not through non-price restrictions. The WTO explicitly recognises anti-dumping duties as a legitimate tariff-based trade remedy under the Anti-Dumping Agreement.
- **C is not correct :** Quotas are quantitative restrictions that cap the volume or value of imports from specific countries regardless of market demand. They are one of the most direct and powerful NTBs by fixing a hard ceiling on import volumes, they completely insulate domestic producers from foreign competition beyond the quota limit. They distort trade far more severely than tariffs because no amount of price reduction by the foreign exporter can break through the quota ceiling.
- **D is not correct :** When governments mandate redundant, time-consuming, or disproportionately expensive testing procedures specifically for imported products, they create a technical barrier to trade. They are NTBs because they are disguised as legitimate safety or quality regulations. In practice, they raise the cost and time of market entry for foreign goods, effectively acting as a trade barrier.

Subject: Economy || Tariffs

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Anti-Dumping (AD) vs Countervailing Duty (CD)
 - AD is triggered by foreign firm selling below normal value, while CD by foreign government subsidising exports
 - WTO Agreement : AD (Anti-Dumping Agreement) & CD (Subsidies & Countervailing Measures Agreement)

- India is among world's largest user of anti-dumping measures
- CD is used selectively against subsidised imports
- Customs duties on merchandise imports are called tariffs. Tariffs give a price advantage to locally-produced goods over similar goods which are imported, and they raise revenues for governments.

🔗 **Further reading:** https://www.wto.org/english/tratop_e/tariffs_e/tariffs_e.htm

27. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Inflation is a sustained and general rise in the price level of goods and services in an economy over a period of time, resulting in a fall in the purchasing power of money. It is measured in India primarily through
 - CPI (Consumer Price Index) : measures retail inflation, used by RBI as the headline inflation target
 - WPI (Wholesale Price Index) : measures wholesale/producer level inflation
- **I is correct :** When the RBI raises the repo rate, borrowing becomes costlier for banks, which in turn raise lending rates for businesses and consumers. This reduces credit offtake, consumption, and investment, directly impacting aggregate demand. Lower demand means less upward pressure on prices. This is the primary monetary policy tool to combat demand-pull inflation. For example, RBI raised the repo rate from 4% to 6.5% between 2022-23 to combat post-COVID inflation surge.
- **II is not correct :** Increasing government expenditure on welfare schemes injects more money into the economy, raising aggregate demand further. It is a counter-productive measure during inflation because it will boost demand when the economy already has excess demand chasing limited supply. Increased government spending is an anti-recession measure.
- **III is correct :** When the RBI raises the cash reserve ratio, banks are required to park a larger share of their deposits with the RBI as cash reserves. This directly reduces the funds available with banks for lending, contracting credit and money supply in the economy. Less money circulating means less spending power, which reduces demand-pull inflationary pressure.
- **IV is correct :** When the government reduces its expenditure by cutting subsidies and rationalising spending, it withdraws money from circulation, reducing aggregate demand. Additionally, a lower fiscal deficit means the government borrows less, keeping interest rates from rising further and reducing the monetisation pressure on RBI. This is a fiscal policy measure to complement monetary tightening during inflation.

Subject: Economy || Inflation

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Phillips Curve : Inflation vs Unemployment
 - It describes the inverse relationship between inflation and unemployment:
 - Low unemployment → workers have bargaining power → wages rise → costs rise → inflation rises
 - High unemployment → weak demand → prices fall → inflation falls
- Stagflation breaks the Phillips Curve: During the 1970s oil crisis and India's post-COVID supply shocks, both inflation and unemployment rose simultaneously — violating the Phillips Curve relationship

🔗 **Further reading:** Core vs Headline Inflation

28. Answer: D

Explanation:

- Credit creation is the process by which commercial banks multiply deposits into a much larger volume of loans and credit in the economy. It is the primary mechanism through which money supply expands beyond the base money injected by the central bank. Bank receives deposit → keeps a fraction as reserve → lends the rest → borrower spends → money gets re-deposited → bank lends again → cycle repeats.
- **I is correct :** Credit creation is not automatic — it requires banks to actively lend out their surplus funds. Bank willingness depends on risk perception, profitability considerations and regulatory environment. When banks become excessively risk-averse (as happened in India during the twin balance sheet crisis (2015-2019)) credit creation collapses even when RBI cuts rates, because banks simply refuse to lend.
- **II is correct :** NPAs are loans that have stopped generating income for banks – borrowers have defaulted or are significantly overdue. High NPAs affect credit creation through :

- Capital erosion : NPAs reduce bank profits and erode capital, limiting further lending capacity
- Risk aversion : banks with high NPAs become extremely cautious about new lending
- Regulatory restrictions : banks with high NPAs face Prompt Corrective Action by RBI, directly restricting their lending activities.

India's NPA crisis (2015-2019) severely impaired credit creation.

- **III is correct** : Under Basel norms, banks must maintain a minimum Capital to Risk-weighted Assets Ratio, currently 11.5% in India, including capital conservation buffer. Capital adequacy directly constrains credit creation because:
 - Banks can only lend a multiple of their capital base due to insufficient capital limits total lending.
 - Every new loan requires additional capital provisioning against its risk weight.
 - Undercapitalised banks cannot expand their loan books regardless of deposit availability.

Subject: Economy || Banking

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Twin Balance Sheet Problem — India's Credit Crisis
 - Corporate balance sheets : over-leveraged companies unable to repay loans
 - Bank balance sheets : high NPAs eroding capital and lending capacity
- Prompt Corrective Action Framework : When a bank's financial health deteriorates beyond threshold levels, RBI places it under PCA, a supervisory framework that:
 - Restricts dividend payments to conserve capital
 - Limits branch expansion to reduce risk exposure
 - Restricts lending to certain high-risk categories
 - In severe cases, prohibits fresh lending altogether

🔍 **Further reading:** Bank Recapitalisation

29. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Economic activities are classified into five sectors based on the nature of work performed and the level of processing involved :
 - Primary : Extraction of natural resources. Examples : Agriculture, mining, fishing, forestry
 - Secondary : Processing and manufacturing. Examples : Steel, textile, construction
 - Tertiary : Services supporting primary and secondary. Examples : Trade, transport, banking
 - Quaternary : Knowledge-based services. Examples : IT, research, consulting
 - Quinary : Highest-level decision making. Examples : Senior government, top executives
- **I is correct** : Primary activities directly involve the extraction, harvesting, or utilisation of natural resources from the earth, water, or atmosphere. Mining extracts minerals, fishing harvests aquatic resources, and forestry involves extraction of timber and forest produce. Mining, fishing and forestry involve direct interaction with nature without any significant processing, making them textbook examples of primary activities. Agriculture is the most dominant primary activity globally.
- **II is not correct** : IT outsourcing by multinational companies to India is a **Tertiary** or **Quaternary** activity, not secondary. Secondary activities involve physical transformation of raw materials into finished goods through manufacturing and processing (like converting iron ore into steel). IT services involve service-based tasks like software development, BPO, and ITES (IT Enabled Services), and focus on knowledge, information, and business services.
- **III is correct** : Tertiary activities are the service sector – they do not produce physical goods but instead facilitate and support the production and distribution of goods produced by primary and secondary sectors. Trade moves goods from producer to consumer, transport physically moves goods and people, communication enables information flow, and banking provides financial intermediation. Trade, transport, communication and banking are tertiary activities.

Subject: Economy || Economic Sectors

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- India moved directly from agrarian to services economy, bypassing the manufacturing led industrialisation phase that characterised growth in China, South Korea, and Taiwan. This has created:

- Jobless growth : services sector is skill-intensive, not labour-intensive
- Highly productive IT sector coexisting with subsistence agriculture
- Make in India initiative is a deliberate attempt to correct this structural anomaly by boosting secondary sector
- The shift toward quaternary and quinary activities reflects the emergence of the knowledge economy where intellectual capital, information, and innovation replace physical labour and natural resources as the primary drivers of value creation
- India spends only ~0.7% of GDP on R&D, far below China (2.4%) and USA (3.1%)

📖 **Further reading:** <https://ncert.nic.in/textbook/pdf/jess202.pdf>

30. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Since 2009, based on the river water quality monitored by State Pollution Control Boards & Pollution Control Committees, CPCB has been identifying polluted river stretches (PRS) in the country.
- For identification of PRS, the water quality data for river monitoring locations with respect to **Biochemical Oxygen Demand (BOD)** parameter is considered. The locations/ stretches of rivers not meeting the Primary water quality criteria for outdoor bathing for BOD i.e. more than 3 mg/L are identified as polluted locations or polluted stretches.
 - If there is a single location on river, rivulet or stream and the location is not complying to BOD, it is identified as Polluted Location.
 - Two or more polluted locations identified on a river in a continuous sequence are considered as a stretch and defined as Polluted River Stretch.

Subject: Environment || Biochemical Oxygen Demand

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Polluted River Stretches (PRS)
 - CPCB has published 4 PRS periodic reports in the year 2009, 2015, 2018 and 2022
 - Number of PRSs has decreased from 351 in the year 2018 to 311 in the year 2022.
 - 106 PRSs have been delisted and improvement in water quality of 74 PRSs have been observed in 2022 as compared to 2018
- National Water Quality Monitoring Network
 - Established by CPCB+SPCBs+PCCs to regularly assess status of water quality of water resources to facilitate prevention and control of pollution in water bodies

📖 **Further reading:** Real-Time Water Quality Monitoring Stations, CPCB

31. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Smog-eating photocatalytic coatings are specially engineered surface treatments containing light-activated compounds, most commonly titanium dioxide (TiO_2), that can chemically break down air pollutants when exposed to sunlight. They have been applied to building facades, road pavements, roof tiles, and even concrete in cities like Milan, Tokyo, and London as a passive, low-maintenance strategy to combat urban air pollution.
- **Statement II is correct and Statement II explains Statement I :** When exposed to UV light, the TiO_2 coating acts as a catalyst, triggering a reaction that breaks down NO_x into harmless nitrates, which are subsequently washed away by rain.
- **Statement III is not correct :** Photocatalytic coatings are not sticky filters. They do not physically trap or hold pollutants. The process is entirely chemical, not physical as the pollutants are destroyed and converted into other compounds, not captured.

Subject: Environment || Photocatalytic Coatings

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Uses of Titanium dioxide (TiO_2)
 - In sunscreen : Acts as a UV filter that sits on top of the skin to reflect, scatter, and absorb harmful UVA and UVB rays like "tiny mirrors" on the skin. Also, it stays on the surface of the skin rather than being absorbed into the body.

- Paints and Coatings: Used in paints for providing lasting white color, brightness, and UV resistance.
- Potential applications in solar cells, as a catalyst for environmental purification (e.g., self-cleaning glass), and in lithium batteries.

Further reading: NO_x Problem in Cities

32. Answer: D

Explanation:

- **Row I is correctly matched :** A parasite lives on or inside a host and derives nutrients at the host's expense without immediately killing it – a long-term exploitative relationship. A tapeworm lives inside the intestines of its host (humans, cattle, pigs), absorbing digested nutrients directly through its body wall. The host survives (often for years) while being gradually weakened.
- **Row II is correctly matched :** A predator actively hunts, kills, and consumes prey – a direct, usually quick interaction resulting in prey death. A ladybug is an example of a predatory insect. It actively hunts and consumes aphids (small plant-sucking insects), eating dozens per day.
- **Row III is correctly matched :** A parasitoid forms a bridge between parasite and predator – it is parasite-like during development but predator-like in outcome. The adult wasp lays eggs inside or on a living host (caterpillars, aphids, beetle larvae). The larvae hatch and feed on the host's tissues from within, keeping it alive just long enough to complete development, eventually killing it. Parasitic wasps (e.g., Cotesia, Ichneumon species) are examples of parasitoids.

Subject: Environment || Ecological Interactions

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Parasitic wasps in Integrated Pest Management
 - Widely used in biological pest control. They are mass-reared and released into fields to control caterpillar and aphid populations, reducing the need for chemical pesticides.
 - Ladybug as both predator and biological control agent : Just like parasitic wasps, ladybugs (ladybirds) are also used in biological pest control. A single ladybug can consume up to 5,000 aphids in its lifetime, making it one of the most economically valuable predatory insects in farming.
- Ectoparasitoid vs. Endoparasitoid
 - Endoparasitoid : larvae develop inside the host's body (e.g., most ichneumon wasps)
 - Ectoparasitoid : larvae feed from outside the host, attached to its surface

Further reading: Symbiotic Interaction

33. Answer: A

Explanation:

- **Row I is correctly matched :** Soil pH is a measure of the acidity or alkalinity of soil. It is a purely physical-chemical property of the environment, making it an abiotic factor. Soil pH directly controls nutrient solubility in soil :
 - In acidic soils (pH < 6) : iron, manganese, and aluminium become overly soluble and toxic to many plants; phosphorus becomes less available.
 - In alkaline soils (pH > 7.5) : iron, zinc, and manganese become insoluble and unavailable to plants.
 Most crops thrive in a slightly acidic to neutral range (pH 6–7) where nutrients are optimally available. pH also determines which microbial communities thrive, indirectly shaping decomposition rates and nutrient cycling.
- **Row II is correctly matched :** Decomposers are living organisms, primarily fungi and bacteria, so they are classified as biotic. They break down dead organic matter (detritus) into simpler inorganic compounds like nitrogen, phosphorus, and carbon back into the soil and atmosphere, making them available for producers (plants) again. Without decomposers, nutrients would remain permanently locked in dead matter and all ecosystems would collapse within a short time.
- **Row III is correctly matched :** Wind is an abiotic factor as it is a non-living phenomenon. Wind performs the functions of wind pollination and wind-aided seed dispersal.
- **Row IV is not correctly matched :** Humus is an abiotic component of the ecosystem as it is non-living, although it originates from the biological decomposition of organic matter such as leaves and plants. It boosts soil fertility by storing nutrients (nitrogen, phosphorus), increases water retention, enhances soil structure, supports beneficial microbial activity, and binds soil particles to mitigate erosion.

Subject: Environment || Ecological Interactions

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Limiting Factors
 - Ecosystem productivity is limited by whichever essential resource is in shortest supply, even if all others are abundant.
 - For example, a plant may have perfect sunlight and water but if soil phosphorus is deficient, growth is stunted.
- Keystone Biotic Factors
 - Some biotic factors have disproportionately large effects on their ecosystem relative to their abundance:
 - Sea otters control sea urchin populations, protecting kelp forests
 - Reintroduction of wolves in Yellowstone National Park triggered a trophic cascade that changed river flow patterns by altering deer grazing behavior, demonstrating how a single biotic factor can reshape even abiotic features of a landscape
 - Elephants create waterholes used by dozens of other species; uproot trees creating grassland habitat

Further reading: Edaphic Factors

34. Answer: C

Explanation:

- **I, II, III and IV are correct :** The Wildlife Protection Act, 1972 (WPA) governs wildlife and habitat conservation in India. Section 24A of the Act states that “protected area” means a **National Park**, a **sanctuary**, a **conservation reserve** or a **community reserve** notified under sections 18, 35, 36A and 36C of the Act.
- **V is not correct :** Biosphere Reserve is not mentioned in the WPA. They are designated by the central government based on UNESCO's criteria.

Subject: Environment || Protected Areas

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Biosphere Reserves
 - Core Zone : strictly protected, no human activity
 - Buffer Zone : limited research and tourism permitted
 - Transition Zone : human settlement and sustainable use allowed
- India has 18 Biosphere Reserves; 12 recognized by UNESCO's World Network of Biosphere Reserves.
- Currently, India's protected area network covers approximately 5% of land area. India is committed to protecting 30% of its land and ocean area by 2030 (30x30 target under Kunming-Montreal Framework, 2022).

Further reading: Convention on Biological Diversity

35. Answer: A

Explanation:

- A food chain is a linear sequence showing how energy and matter flow from one organism to another through feeding relationships in an ecosystem. Every ecosystem has two fundamental types of food chains running simultaneously : the Grazing Food Chain, which begins with living green plants, and the Detritus Food Chain, which begins with dead organic matter (detritus).
- **I is not correct :** Energy in an ecosystem does not cycle like nutrients. It flows in a unidirectional manner—from the sun to producers and then to consumers, with a significant portion lost as heat at each step due to thermodynamic laws. Once lost as heat, energy cannot be reused by the ecosystem, so it cannot form a cycle.
- **II is not correct :** Energy decreases at each successive trophic level, typically following the 10% law. Biomagnification refers to the increasing concentration of pollutants, not energy. Since much of the energy is lost as heat during transfer, higher trophic levels always have less energy, which limits the length of food chains.
- **III is correct :** On average, 10% of the energy available at one trophic level is transferred to the next higher level. This ecological principle is known as **Lindeman's 10% Law** and explains why food chains are typically limited to four or five levels and energy flow is always depicted as an upright pyramid, with the most energy at the producer level and the least at the apex predator level. Approximately 90% of energy is lost at each level, primarily as heat through metabolic processes such as respiration, digestion, and movement. While 10% is the widely accepted average, actual ecological efficiency can vary between 5% and 20% depending on the specific ecosystem and species involved.

Subject: Environment || Food Chain

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Detritus Food Chain dominate in terrestrial forests :
 - In forests, a large proportion of plant biomass is in wood, bark, and roots : structures that herbivores cannot easily digest or access.
 - Most of this biomass eventually becomes leaf litter, dead wood, and humus : entering the DFC through decomposers.
 - Studies show that in temperate forests, up to 80–90% of net primary production enters the DFC rather than the GFC
- Pyramid of Energy
 - Unlike pyramids of numbers or biomass (which can be inverted), the pyramid of energy is always upright

🔍 **Further reading:** Detritivores vs. Decomposers

36. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Greenhouse gases (GHGs) such as carbon dioxide (CO₂), methane (CH₄), nitrous oxide (N₂O), and water vapour trap outgoing infrared radiation from Earth's surface, causing the enhanced greenhouse effect and progressive global warming. GHGs have profound cascading effects on water ecosystems – both freshwater (rivers, lakes, wetlands) and marine (oceans, coral reefs).
- **I is correct** : Warmer water temperatures directly accelerate the growth and reproduction of cyanobacteria (blue-green algae) and other algal species in rivers and lakes. GHG-driven warming creates ideal conditions for blooms:
 - Higher temperatures speed up algal metabolism and reproduction.
 - Warm upper layer sits over a cold lower layer, preventing mixing and concentrating nutrients near the surface.

Harmful Algal Blooms release cyanotoxins that poison drinking water, kill fish, and make water bodies unusable for agriculture and recreation.

- **II is correct** : Dissolved oxygen (DO) is the oxygen dissolved in water that aquatic organisms (fish, invertebrates, amphibians) depend on for respiration. Warmer water holds significantly less dissolved oxygen than cooler water (~14.6 mg/L DO at 0°C, ~9.1 mg/L at 20°C and only ~7.5 mg/L at 30°C). GHG-driven warming therefore directly reduces DO in rivers and lakes. Additionally, algal blooms worsen this further. When blooms die and decompose, bacterial decomposition consumes enormous amounts of oxygen, creating hypoxic (low oxygen) or anoxic (zero oxygen) zones. Fishes and other aerobic aquatic life suffocate and die in these zones, known as "dead zones".
- **III is not correct** : Coral bleaching is a significant consequence of climate change, but it occurs exclusively in marine (saltwater) ecosystems, not in freshwater rivers or lakes. Corals are marine invertebrates that live in shallow tropical oceans. **Freshwater rivers and lakes do not contain coral reefs.**
- **IV is correct** : As river and lake temperatures rise due to greenhouse warming, cold-water fish species which require cool, well-oxygenated water are forced to migrate. Since rivers generally flow from cool highlands to warm lowlands, cold-water species like trout, salmon, and mahseer migrate upstream toward mountain headwaters seeking cooler refuge – called "upstream migration".

Subject: Environment || GHGs

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Ocean Acidification
 - Oceans absorb approximately 25–30% of all CO₂ emitted by human activities, which dissolves in seawater forming carbonic acid (H₂CO₃), which dissociates to release hydrogen ions and lowers ocean pH. As more and more CO₂ emitted in the atmosphere, more is absorbed by the oceans, further lowering the ocean pH.
 - Since pre-industrial times, ocean pH has dropped from 8.2 to 8.1 — a 26% increase in acidity.
- Dead Zones
 - The world's largest dead zone is in the Gulf of Mexico — fed by nutrient runoff from Mississippi River agriculture.
 - In India, dead zones have been reported in Chilika Lake and parts of the Arabian Sea.

🔍 **Further reading:** Detritivores vs. Decomposers

37. Answer: D

Explanation:

- **I is correct** : The term “environment” is not mentioned in the Seventh Schedule to the Constitution of India. List III (Concurrent List) mentions “Forests”.
- **II is correct** : The National Environment Policy, 2006 defines the term environment : “environment comprises all entities, natural or man-made, external to oneself, and their interrelationships, which provide value, now or perhaps in the future, to humankind”.
- **III is correct** : Green federalism is a governance model where environmental protection responsibilities are shared between central and state/local governments. It acknowledges that environmental problems such as air pollution, river degradation, forest loss, climate change do not respect political boundaries and therefore require both central coordination and state-level implementation.

Subject: Environment || Green Federalism

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- 42nd Constitutional Amendment, 1976
 - Inserted Articles 48A and 51A(g), making environmental protection a DPSP and a Fundamental Duty of citizens respectively.
 - Moved Forests and Wildlife from the State List to the Concurrent List, giving the Centre authority to legislate on these subjects nationwide.

Further reading: Forest Rights Act

38. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **II and III are correct** : Plants primarily absorb nitrogen from the soil through their roots in the form of inorganic nitrates (NO_3^-) and ammonium ions (NH_4^+).
- **I is not correct** : Plants do not directly take atmospheric nitrogen (N_2). Leguminous plants (peas, beans, lentils) can indirectly benefit from atmospheric nitrogen through their symbiotic relationship with Rhizobium bacteria housed in root nodules, but it is the bacteria fixing the nitrogen, not the plant itself.

Subject: Environment || Nitrogen Uptake

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Nitrogen Use Efficiency
 - On average, plants use only 30–50% of applied nitrogen fertilizer, the rest is lost through:
 - Leaching : NO_3^- washes into groundwater (causes eutrophication)
 - Denitrification : soil bacteria convert NO_3^- back to N_2 and N_2O
 - Volatilization : NH_3 gas lost to atmosphere

Further reading: Nano Urea

39. Answer: D

Explanation:

- Fertigation is the technique of delivering dissolved fertilizers directly to plants through an irrigation system, combining the words fertilization and irrigation into a single integrated process.
- **I is correct** : Conventional fertilization involves spreading fertilizers uniformly across the entire field surface, regardless of where plant roots actually are. This means :
 - Nutrients fall on inter-row spaces where no roots exist.
 - Heavy rainfall or irrigation leaches nutrients deep below the root zone.
 - Surface-applied nutrients may volatilize (especially nitrogen as ammonia).
 - Nutrients bind to soil particles far from the root zone.
 Fertigation delivers nutrients directly and precisely to the active root zone through irrigation water, ensuring nutrients are available exactly where and when the plant needs them.
- **II is correct** : Fertigation requires fertilizers to be water-soluble or liquid, since they must dissolve in irrigation water and flow through pipes.
- **III is correct** : Fertigation reduces soil compaction by minimizing the need for heavy machinery traffic to apply fertilizer, as nutrients are delivered through the irrigation system. By reducing surface traffic, preserving soil structure, and allowing for localized, light applications, fertigation maintains better soil porosity and reduces the creation of hard-packed soil layers, particularly with subsurface drip systems.
- **IV is correct** : Fertigation is highly compatible with pressurized systems, including surface drip, subsurface drip, and sprinkler systems.
 - Drip fertigation combines the precision of drip irrigation with targeted nutrient delivery.

- Sprinkler fertigation is common in field crops like wheat and maize where drip installation is economically impractical.
- Subsurface drip fertigation eliminates surface evaporation entirely and delivers nutrients with surgical precision.

Subject: Environment || Fertigation

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Fertigation in India
 - Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchayee Yojana (Per Drop More Crop) : Subsidizes drip and sprinkler systems, enabling fertigation adoption
 - National Mission for Sustainable Agriculture : Promotes fertigation as part of climate-smart agriculture
 - Nano Urea (IFFCO) : Liquid nano-urea designed specifically for fertigation and foliar application
 - Soil Health Card Scheme : Provides soil nutrient data to guide fertigation schedules

🔍 **Further reading:** Herbigation

40. Answer: D

Explanation:

- Aerosols are tiny solid particles or liquid droplets suspended in the Earth's atmosphere. They originate from both natural sources (volcanic eruptions, sea spray, dust storms, wildfires, and biological matter) and anthropogenic sources (fossil fuel and other sources of carbon emissions).
- **I is correct :** Most aerosols, particularly sulfate aerosols, sea salt, and mineral dust, are light-coloured and highly reflective. When sunlight strikes these particles, it is scattered and reflected back into space before reaching Earth's surface. This reduces the amount of solar energy reaching the surface, causing a net cooling effect on the planet.
- **II is correct :** Water vapour in the atmosphere cannot spontaneously condense into cloud droplets in perfectly clean air as it requires a solid or liquid surface to nucleate upon. Aerosol particles serve as microscopic cloud condensation nuclei around which water vapour condenses to form cloud droplets and as ice nuclei around which ice crystals form in cold clouds.
- **III is correct :** Aerosols act as condensation nuclei, increasing the number of smaller droplets in clouds – brighter and more reflective. This makes clouds whiter, thicker, and more reflective, scattering more sunlight back into space.
- **IV is correct :** Some aerosols such as black carbon (soot) and certain types of mineral dust, play a complex role in the climate system by absorbing incoming solar radiation, which directly warms the surrounding atmosphere. This atmospheric heating can lead to the suppression of cloud formation.

Subject: Environment || Aerosols

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Geoengineering
 - Deliberately inject sulfate aerosols into the stratosphere at ~20km altitude using aircraft or balloons.
 - Could theoretically offset 1.5–2°C of warming globally.
 - Currently not governed by any international framework which is a major gap in climate governance

🔍 **Further reading:** Volcanic Aerosols

41. Answer: A

Explanation:

- The global aviation industry contributes disproportionately to climate change because its total climate impact, including non-CO₂ effects, is roughly three times higher than the warming caused by its CO₂ emissions alone.
- **Statement II is correct and Statement II explains Statement I :** Aircraft engines emit water vapour and soot particles that form condensation trails (contrails) and cirrus clouds, which trap outgoing longwave

radiation and cause net warming. Persistent contrails created by aircraft engines act as ice clouds that trap heat radiating from the Earth's surface, contributing more to warming than aviation CO₂.

- **Statement III is correct and Statement III explains Statement I :** Aircraft engines emit nitrogen oxides (NO_x) at high altitudes (9-12km), which primarily contribute to the formation of ozone in the upper troposphere **and lower atmosphere**. While ozone is a protective layer in the stratosphere, it acts as a harmful pollutant and a potent greenhouse gas in the lower atmosphere, contributing to global warming. Sunlight breaks down NO_x and produces free oxygen atoms which quickly bind with O₂ to create ozone.

Subject: Environment || Carbon Emissions

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Cirrus clouds
 - During daytime, they reflect some incoming solar radiation (cooling effect)
 - During night-time, they trap outgoing longwave (infrared) radiation from Earth's surface (warming effect)
- International aviation is governed by International Civil Aviation Organization (a UN agency) and is not covered by national Paris Agreement targets

🔍 **Further reading:** Sustainable Aviation Fuels

42. Answer: B

Explanation

- In India, the "Minus 5 and Plus 10" formula involves reducing the area of rice cultivation by 5 million hectares while increasing rice production by 10 million tons in the same area. Aimed at optimizing land use, it would free up space for the cultivation of pulses and oilseeds, which are essential for ensuring nutritional security and reducing import dependency.

Subject: Environment || New Initiatives

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- India is the world's largest producer, consumer, and importer of pulses
- Pulses contribute nearly 20-25 percent of total protein intake in Indian diets. However, the per capita consumption of pulses continues to fall short of the recommended 85 grams per day, contributing to protein-energy malnutrition across the country
- Mission for Aatmanirbharta in Pulses (2025–26 to 2030–31)
 - To drive production of pulses to 350 lakh tonnes by 2030-31 (252.38 lakh tonnes in 2024-25)
 - To expand the area under pulses cultivation by an additional 35 lakh hectares, targeting rice fallows and other suitable lands, while promoting intercropping and crop diversification
 - To ensure 100 percent procurement of Tur, Urad, and Masoor at MSP for four years
 - Production and distribution of 126 lakh quintals of certified seeds and the free provision of 88 lakh seed kits to farmers

🔍 **Further reading:** SATHI - Seed Authentication, Traceability & Holistic Inventory

43. Answer: B

Explanation

- The Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) is an EU policy designed to prevent "carbon leakage", where companies move production to countries with laxer emissions rules. Formally effective from January 1, 2026, it forces importers to pay a levy on carbon-intensive goods (steel, cement, aluminum, etc.) equivalent to EU carbon prices, ensuring fair competition. It is intended to ensure that imported goods bear a carbon cost equivalent to domestic products.
- Importers must report the embedded emissions in their products and surrender CBAM certificates. The price of these certificates is based on the EU Emission Trading System (ETS) allowance price. If a carbon price is already paid in the country of origin, it can be deducted.

Subject: Environment || CBAM

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- European Green Deal

- To reduce net greenhouse gas emissions by at least 55 per cent from 1990 levels and achieve climate neutrality by 2050
- India is the largest supplier of iron and steel to the EU market (about \$4.4–4.6 billion in 2023 and 2024)

🔍 **Further reading:** National Green Hydrogen Mission in steel sector

44. Answer: B

Explanation

- In a landmark development for environmental governance, municipalities in the Peruvian Amazon have granted legal rights to native Amazonian Stingless Bees, becoming the first jurisdictions in the world to recognise an insect species as a rights-bearing entity.
- Amazonian Stingless Bees are responsible for pollinating more than 80% of plant species in the Amazon rainforest. Among the oldest bee groups, it has existed for ~80 million years since the time of dinosaurs. Around 500 species exist globally, with over 170 species recorded in Peru. They are deeply connected with the traditional knowledge systems of indigenous communities such as the Asháninka and Kukama-Kukamiria.

Subject: Environment || Species in News

Question type: Conceptual and Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Amazonian Stingless Bees
 - They are not completely devoid of a stinger; rather they possess a vestigial stinger that is too small to be used for defense. Hence, they defend their hives by biting or secreting irritating resins
 - Highly social (eusocial) insects living in perennial colonies, often nesting in hollow tree trunks.

🔍 **Further reading:** Meliponiculture

45. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correctly matched:** Kanganahalli Inscription found on a stupa in Karnataka identifies Ashoka as "Ranyo Asoka" (King Ashoka). This is historically important because most Ashokan inscriptions refer to the emperor as Devanampiya Piyadasi (Beloved of the Gods, He Who Looks with Favour) rather than using his personal name.
- **Pair 2 is not correctly matched:** Sannati Inscription located in Karnataka is the only site with all 14 Major Rock Edicts and unique Kalinga Edicts. It is considered a unique southern site where these edicts were discovered together, showing Mauryan administrative and cultural influence in the Deccan. In Minor Rock Edict 3, Ashoka greets the Sangha and recommends six Buddhist texts.
- **Pair 3 is correctly matched:** Kalinga Edicts (Dhauili & Jaugada) found in Odisha contains Ashoka's declaration: "All men are my children." These were issued after the Kalinga War, which deeply affected Ashoka.

Subject: Ancient India || Mauryan Empire

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- **Allahabad/Queen's Edicts:** Mentions Queen Karuvaki, Ashoka's second queen. Reflects Ashoka's commitment to Buddhism and Dharma. Includes Samudragupta's inscription.
- **Sarnath Inscription:** Found in Uttar Pradesh. Praises Ashoka's promotion of Dhamma and Buddhist institutions.
- **Rummindei Pillar (Lumbini):** Found in Nepal, Buddha's birthplace. Mentions tax exemptions (exemption of Bali) and payment of only one-eighth of Bhaga (share of produce).

🔍 **Further reading:** https://ignca.gov.in/Asi_data/5282.pdf

46. Answer: D

Explanation:

- The Guptas adopted several cavalry-related practices and attire from the Kushans, who had strong Central Asian nomadic traditions of horsemanship. These included:
 - Saddle – Provided better balance and stability for horse riders.
 - Reins – Allowed improved control of horses during cavalry combat.
 - Buttoned coats – Practical clothing for mounted warriors, suited to steppe traditions.

- Trousers and boots – More suitable for horse riding compared to traditional Indian garments like dhoti.
- These innovations enhanced the mobility and effectiveness of Gupta cavalry, contributing to their reputation as excellent horsemen.

Subject: Ancient India | | Gupta empire

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- **Army during Gupta period:** During the Gupta period, the king maintained a permanent standing army, which was occasionally reinforced by contingents supplied by feudatory chiefs. In the composition of the army, the traditional prominence of chariots and war elephants declined, while cavalry and horse archery assumed greater importance. Evidence from seals and inscriptions refers to military officials such as Baladhikrita and Mahabaladhikrita, who served as commanders responsible for major divisions of the army, particularly infantry and cavalry.

🔍 **Further reading:** Officers in the Gupta Empire

47. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The Gathasattasai (also known as Gaha Sattasai or Gathasaptashati) is a celebrated Prakrit anthology of short lyrical verses. It is attributed to King Hala, the 17th ruler of the Satavahana dynasty, who reigned in the 1st century AD. The work consists of 700 verses (hence the name "Saptashati" or "Sattasai," meaning seven hundred) composed in Maharashtri Prakrit. These verses primarily explore themes of love, human emotions, and rural life.

Subject: Ancient India | | Satavahanas

Question type: Factual

Trinetra Approach

- "Gatha" = verse and "Saptasati/Sattasai" = 700, so it clearly indicates a collection of verses, not a drama or treatise.
- The title is Prakrit/Sanskrit-based, not Tamil, eliminating the Sangam option; it is also not typical of Buddhist Pali texts.
- Hence the best match is (b) a Prakrit anthology attributed to King Hala.

Extended Knowledge

● Satavahana Literature

- The Satavahana rulers actively patronized Prakrit, making it the language of court and literature.
- Gunadhy's Brihatkatha: Written in the Paishachi dialect of Prakrit, this work is considered a masterpiece of ancient Indian storytelling.
- Other notable literary works from this period include: Lilavati by Kutuhala and Kamasutra by Vatsyayana.

🔍 **Further reading:** Inscriptions of Satavahanas

48. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Korkai was an ancient port city and the early capital of the Pandya kingdom. It is extensively mentioned in Sangam literature (such as Agananuru and Maduraikkanchi) as a premier emporium for maritime trade. Korkai was globally renowned for its pearl fisheries in the Gulf of Mannar. Classical Greco-Roman accounts, including the Periplus of the Erythraean Sea and Ptolemy's Geographia (which refers to it as Kolkhai), highlight its significance as a major trade link with the Roman world.

Subject: Ancient India | | Ports

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- **Poompuhar:** Also known as Kaveripoompattinam, situated at the mouth of the Kaveri River in Tamil Nadu. It is a crucial port city in the Chola Kingdom, Poompuhar was an important center for maritime trade, connecting South India to various overseas markets.
- **Muchiri (Muziris):** Situated near present-day Kodungalloor in Kerala. Muziris was one of the major ports on the Malabar Coast, serving as a key link in ancient maritime trade routes. It was well-known for its spice trade and had connections with the Mediterranean and Red Sea.

🔍 **Further reading:** Read about Sopara, Arikamedu and Tamralipti

49. Answer: D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Ajivikas doctrine centred on Niyati (absolute determinism). They believed everything is predetermined and human effort cannot change destiny, which effectively negates the moral role of karma.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Uchchedvad's promoter was Ajita Kesh Kambali. It holds that the self is destroyed at death and there is no afterlife or rebirth.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Akriyavada, propounded by thinkers like Purana Kassapa, teaches that human actions have no moral consequences and good or bad deeds do not produce karmic results.

Subject: Ancient India | Religion & Philosophy

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- **Nityavad:** Its promoter was Pakudha Kachaiyan. He told only seven elements, such as earth, water, fire, air, happiness, sorrow and soul (these elements do not interact with one another).
- **Sandehvad:** Its promoter was Sanjay Beluttaputra. He neither accepted any opinion nor denied any opinion.

🔍 **Further reading:** <https://egyankosh.ac.in/bitstream/123456789/64789/1/Unit12.pdf>

50. Answer: C

Explanation:

- **Sutkagendor** – Located in south-western Balochistan near the Makran coast, close to the Iran–Pakistan border. It is the westernmost Harappan site.
- **Shortugai** – Located in northern Afghanistan (Oxus region). Though north, it lies east of Sutkagendor longitudinally.
- **Harappa** – In Punjab, Pakistan, on the Ravi River.
- **Rakhigarhi** – In Haryana, India, east of Harappa and currently the largest Harappan site.



Subject: Ancient India | Harappan civilization

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- **Harappa:** Harappa, a city of the IVC, existed from 2600 BCE to 1900 BCE. Daya Ram Sahni excavated the Harappa site on the bank of the Ravi River. The town was laid out on a grid plan and had several impressive public buildings, including a granary and a citadel. The city of Harappa was divided into two parts: the citadel and the lower town.
- **Rakhigarhi:** It was excavated by Prof. Surajbhan Acharya Bhagwande. It is the largest site of Indus valley civilization.

🔍 **Further reading:** <https://www.thehindu.com/news/national/haryana/no-cheer-in-rakhigarhi-over-plan-to-develop-harappan-cultural-site/article70587485.ece>

51. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The Memory of the World (MoW) Program was launched by the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) in 1992. It aims to safeguard documentary heritage of humanity and facilitate preservation, enable universal access and enhance public awareness about documentary heritage. The Ramcharitmanas, Panchatantra and Sahṛdayāloka-Locana have been included in 'UNESCO's Memory of the World Asia-Pacific Regional Register' in 2024.

Subject: Culture || UNESCO initiatives

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

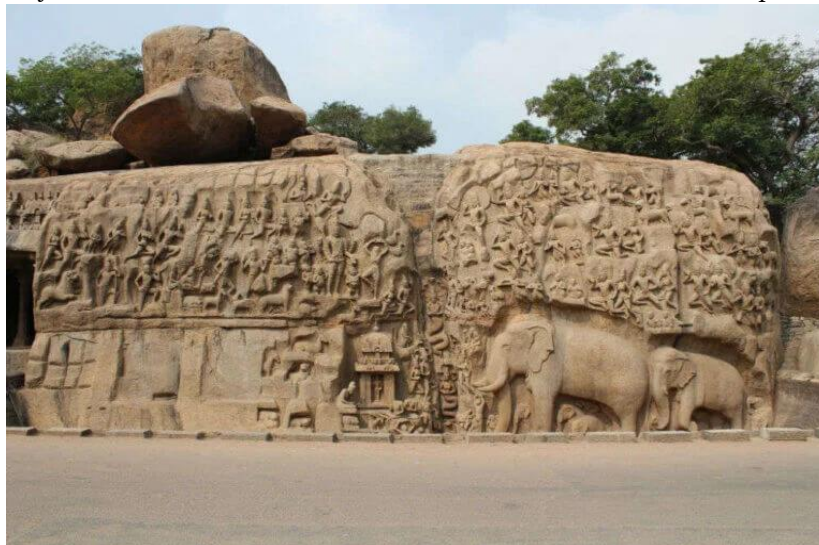
- **Ramcharitmanas:** Authored by 16th century Indian poet Goswami Tulsidas. It is an epic poem that narrates the life of Lord Rama. It is based on the Sanskrit epic Ramayana and is written in the Awadhi dialect of Hindi. The poem is divided into seven chapters, or Kandas, that tell the story of Lord Ram from his birth to becoming the King of Ayodhya.
- **Panchatantra:** It is a collection of folktales and fables that were believed to have been originally written in Sanskrit by Vishnu Sharma more than 2500 years ago. It is a book of Niti, the wise conduct of life, written in the form of a chain of simple stories. Each story has a moral and philosophical theme, aiming to guide the reader in attaining success in life by understanding human nature.

🔍 **Further reading:** Read about Samaveda and Tirukural

52. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The Descent of the Ganges, also known as Arjuna's Penance, is a massive open-air rock relief monument located at Mahabalipuram (Mamallapuram) in Tamil Nadu carved from two adjoining granite boulders during the 7th century CE by artisans of the Pallava dynasty. It features over 100 intricate carvings of deities, sages, mythical beings, animals, and natural elements, centered around a dramatic cleft in the rock that evokes the flow of water. Created under the patronage of King Narasimhavarman I (r. 630–668 CE), the relief is part of the broader Group of Monuments at Mahabalipuram, a coastal religious and port complex established by the Pallavas to showcase their architectural and artistic prowess.



Subject: Culture || Sculpture

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- **Mamallapuram**
 - It was founded by the Pallava king Narasimhavarman I in the 7th century AD.
 - It includes monuments like the Pancha Rathas, Cave Temples, Arjuna's Penance or Descent of the Ganges, and Shore Temples.
- In 1984, UNESCO declared Mamallapuram a World Heritage Site due to its cultural significance.

🔍 **Further reading:** Read about Pancha Rathas and Shore temple

53. Answer: A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Somnath Temple is traditionally regarded as the first among the twelve Jyotirlingas of Lord Shiva, as mentioned in the Shiva Purana and Dwadasha Jyotirlinga Stotram.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The present Somnath Temple is designed in the Kailash Mahameru Prasad style, which is a key manifestation of the Māru-Gurjara (also known as Chaulukya or Solanki) architectural tradition. This architectural style, prevalent in Gujarat and Rajasthan between the 11th and 13th centuries, is characterized by its meticulous stone carving, high plinths, and intricate sculptural work.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The present structure was reconstructed after Indian independence, with the initiative taken by Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel in 1947, and the Pran-Pratistha was performed in 1951 by Rajendra Prasad, not during the Gupta period.

Subject: Culture || Architecture

Question type: Factual

Relevance: Somnath Swabhiman Parv

Trinetra Approach

- The Gupta period ended around the 6th century CE, but the temple was destroyed by Mahmud of Ghazni in 1026 CE, so the present structure cannot belong to the Gupta period → Statement 3 is wrong.
- Eliminate all options containing 3 → (b), (c), (d).
- The only option left is (a) 1 and 2 only.

Extended Knowledge

- **Somnath Temple**
 - Situated at the confluence of Kapila, Hiran, and Saraswati rivers with the Arabian Sea.
 - First major attack in 1026 AD by Mahmud of Ghazni; documented by Persian scholar Al-Biruni.
 - The temple was looted and destroyed multiple times, including in 1026, 1297, 1394, and 1706 CE (Aurangzeb). 2026 marks 1,000 years since the first attack, a significant civilisational milestone.

🔍 **Further reading:** 12 Jyotirlingas and their Location

54. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Amir Khusrau was a 13th century Sufi poet and musician who was bestowed with the title of Tuti-yi-Hind, the 'Parrot of India'. His real name was Abu'l Hasan Yamin ud-Din Khusrau and was born in Patiali, Etah district of Uttar Pradesh.
- **Point 1 is correct:** He is credited with creating new ragas and developing musical forms like Tarana (a rhythmic, fast-paced vocal composition) and Khayal (a form of classical Hindustani music).
- **Point 2 is correct:** He is credited for developing Hindavi, a precursor to modern Hindi and Urdu. His literary works blended Persian, Arabic, and Indian traditions, enriching Indian linguistic heritage.
- **Point 3 is correct:** Amir Khusrau was one of the first expounders of the art of making Ghazal and Qawwali (devotional Sufi music traditions).
- **Point 4 is incorrect:** Padmavat was written by Malik Muhammad Jayasi in the 16th century, not by Amir Khusrau.

Subject: Medieval India || Sufism

Question type: Factual

Relevance: Amir Khusrau was recently honored by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the 25th edition of the Jahan-e-Khusrau festival in Delhi

Extended Knowledge

- **Amir Khusrau**
 - Amir Khusrau was the beloved disciple of Nizamuddin Auliya and drew spiritual inspiration from him, shaping his poetry and music.
 - Sultan Jalaluddin Khalji honored him with the title of Amir in recognition of his literary excellence.

🔍 **Further reading:** <https://www.ndtv.com/india-news/he-called-sanskrit-worlds-best-language-pm-modi-on-sufi-poet-amir-khusrau-7818867>

55. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Charasa was a traditional bullock-driven water-lifting device used in medieval India for irrigation. It worked through a rope-and-bucket mechanism attached to a well. A roller or pulley fixed between wooden forks was placed at the edge of the well, and a rope passed over it with a bucket tied to one end and a bullock to the other. When the bullock moved forward, the bucket was pulled up from the well, and another person emptied the water into irrigation channels. This device was described by Babur in his memoir Baburnama, which matches the description given in the question.

Subject: Medieval India || Technological Progress

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- Araghatta was an ancient Indian irrigation device consisting of a large wheel with earthen pots fixed around its rim. As the wheel rotated—usually powered by animals or humans—the pots dipped into a water source and lifted water for irrigation.
- Dhenkli is a manual lever-based water-lifting device operated by human effort, not by bullocks.
- Shaduf is a traditional human-operated water-lifting device used mainly in ancient Egypt and West Asia for irrigation. It consists of a long pole balanced on a pivot, with a bucket on one end and a counterweight on the other.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://egyankosh.ac.in/bitstream/123456789/44531/1/Unit-23.pdf>

56. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Row I is correctly matched :** Madam Bhikaji Cama published the revolutionary journal Bande Mataram from Paris starting in 1909.
- Row II is not correctly matched :** While Shyamji Krishna Varma did publish The Indian Sociologist, it was published from London, not Berlin.
- Row III is correctly matched :** Lala Hardayal was the key leader and editor of the Ghadar newspaper, which was published by the Ghadar Party in San Francisco starting in 1913

Subject: Modern India || Newspapers

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

• Ghadar Movement

- It began in 1913 when a group of Indian immigrants, mainly Punjabis (largely Sikhs, along with Hindus and Muslims), founded the Ghadar Party in San Francisco, California.
- Founding Leaders**
 - Lala Har Dayal – a revolutionary intellectual who served as the party's key ideologue.
 - Sohan Singh Bhakna – the party's first president.
 - Kartar Singh Sarabha, Baba Gurdit Singh, and Bhai Parmanand were among its most prominent activists.
- The movement's headquarters, "Yugantar Ashram", published the newspaper Ghadar in Punjabi, Urdu, and other Indian languages to spread the message of freedom. Its motto was simple yet powerful: "We shall be free; we shall have our homeland."

🔗 **Further reading:** Contribution of Madam Bhikaji Cama

57. Answer: C

Explanation:

- The Wagon Tragedy occurred on November 10, 1921, during the Mappila Uprising (also known as the Malabar Rebellion) in Kerala. Following the suppression of the rebellion, British authorities packed approximately 100 prisoners into a closed, airtight freight wagon to transport them from Tirur to the Central Prison in Podanur. Due to a lack of ventilation, 67 of the prisoners died of suffocation during the journey. This event is often compared to the Black Hole of Calcutta in terms of its notoriety during the colonial period

Subject: Modern India || Popular uprisings after 1857

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- Mappila (Moplah) Uprising (1921)**

- The Mappilas (Moplahs), descendants of Arab settlers in Malabar, mainly worked as tenant cultivators or landless labourers. They were severely affected by the introduction of the Ryotwari revenue system under British rule.
- The immediate trigger was the Non-Cooperation Movement launched by Congress along with the Khilafat Movement.
- Grievances included insecure tenancy, high rents, renewal fees, illegal cesses, and excessive land revenue, along with a pro-landlord bias of the police and judiciary, pushing peasants into extreme poverty.
- The British administration portrayed the rebellion as a communal conflict (Muslim peasants vs. Hindu landlords), though it largely originated from agrarian exploitation.
- Mahatma Gandhi expressed support for the movement as part of the broader anti-colonial struggle.

🔍 **Further reading:** Read about Indigo revolt, Santhal and Telangana rebellion

58. Answer: A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929 (popularly known as the Sarda Act) fixed the minimum age of marriage at 18 years for boys and 14 years for girls.
- **Statement 2 is incorrect:** While Behramji Malabari was a prominent Parsi reformer who fought against child marriage, his specific campaign led to the Age of Consent Act, 1891, which raised the age of consent from 10 to 12 years. The 1929 Act was primarily the result of efforts by Harbilas Sarda, after whom the Act is named.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Act was not limited to Hindus; it applied to all communities (all Indians) in British India. Earlier legislation, like the Native Marriage Act (1872), had limited application, but the 1929 Act was a more comprehensive measure for all subjects of British India.

Subject: Modern India | | Socio-religious reform movements

Question type: Factual, Analytical

Trinetra Approach

- **Extreme word check:** Statement 3 uses “only to Hindus” — colonial reform laws usually applied broadly, so eliminate it.
- **Statement 2 ->** The Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929 is named after Harbilas Sarda, who introduced the bill. Hence, when the Act already carries Sarda’s name, attributing the campaign to Malabari is likely incorrect.

Extended Knowledge

- **Age of Consent Act, 1891:**
 - Introduced on January 9, 1891, to amend Section 375 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860 and the Code of Criminal Procedure, 1882, with the efforts of social reformer V.M. Malabari.
 - Under this Act, marriage of girls below the age of 12 years was legally made illegal.

🔍 **Further reading:** Phulmoni Das Case

59. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Mahatma Gandhi made the statement “I want world sympathy in this battle of Right against Might” while explaining the objective of the Salt Satyagraha (Dandi March). By marching from Sabarmati Ashram to Dandi and openly violating the Salt Law, Gandhi aimed to expose the injustice of British rule before the international community and gain global moral support for India’s freedom struggle.

Subject: Modern India | | Gandhian Movements

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- The Dandi March was an act of nonviolent civil disobedience led by Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi.
- The march lasted from 12th March, 1930 to 6th April, 1930 as a direct action campaign of tax resistance and nonviolent protest against the British salt monopoly.

- On 12th March, Gandhiji set out from Sabarmati with 78 followers on a 241-mile march to the coastal town of Dandi on the Arabian Sea. There, Gandhi and his supporters were to defy British policy by making salt from seawater.

🔍 **Further reading:** Rowlatt satyagraha and its outcomes

60. Answer: C

Explanation:

- The Communal Award (also known as MacDonald Award) was created by the British prime minister Ramsay MacDonald on 16 August 1932; and was announced after the Round Table Conference (1930–32). It is based on the findings of the Indian Franchise Committee (also called the Lothian Committee). It established separate electorates and reserved seats for minorities, including the depressed classes which were granted seventy-eight reserved seats.
- Statement 1 is correct:** Mahatma Gandhi opposed the Communal Award (1932) because it introduced separate electorates for the Depressed Classes, which he believed would fragment Hindu society. This led to his fast unto death in Yerwada Jail.
- Statement 2 is correct:** B. R. Ambedkar supported the award, as it provided separate electorates and political safeguards for the Depressed Classes, strengthening their independent political voice.
- Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Indian National Congress did not accept the award without reservations. Instead, it adopted a unique stance of "neither acceptance nor rejection".

Subject: Modern India || CDM & Round table conference

Question type: Analytical

Trinetra Approach

- Conflict clue:** The issue led to the Poona Pact, which itself implies Gandhi opposed the separate electorates → Statement 1 likely correct.
- Interest lens:** B. R. Ambedkar demanded political safeguards for Depressed Classes → Statement 2 likely correct.
- Extreme wording test:** Indian National Congress "accepted without any reservations" is an absolute phrase → usually incorrect.

Extended Knowledge

- Provisions of Communal Award**
 - In provincial legislatures, seats were to be distributed on communal basis
 - Existing seats of provincial legislatures were to be doubled
 - Muslims wherever minority granted weightage
 - Except in NWFP, 3% seats reserved for women in all provinces
 - Depressed classes to be accorded status of minority
 - Allocation of seats were to be made for labourers, landlords, traders and industrialists.

🔍 **Further reading:** Poona Pact

61. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Point 1 is correct:** The Discovery of India was written by Jawaharlal Nehru between 1942 and 1945 during his imprisonment at Ahmednagar Fort. It provides a comprehensive account of Indian history, culture, and philosophy.
- Point 2 is correct:** Glimpses of World History is a collection of 196 letters written by Jawaharlal Nehru to his daughter, Indira Gandhi, between 1930 and 1933 while he was in various prisons. It offers a panoramic view of human civilization from ancient times to the early 20th century.
- Point 3 is incorrect:** India Wins Freedom was not written by Jawaharlal Nehru. It is the autobiographical narrative and memoir of Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, India's first Education Minister. The book offers an insider's perspective on the Indian independence movement and the Partition.

Subject: Modern India || Contribution of leaders

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- Contribution of Jawaharlal Nehru to the Freedom Struggle**
 - Entered the Indian National Congress in 1919 and became a key leader under Mahatma Gandhi.
 - As Congress President at the Lahore Session of the Indian National Congress (1929), declared Purna Swaraj and hoisted the tricolour on the Ravi River.

- Represented India internationally at the League Against Imperialism (Brussels, 1927), linking India's struggle with global anti-colonial movements.

🔗 **Further reading:** Key works of Mahatma Gandhi, Bal Gangadhar Tilak and Maulana Abul Kalam Azad

62. Answer: A

Explanation:

- **(4) Early Harvest Scheme (EHS):** An Early Harvest Scheme (EHS) is a precursor to an FTA/CECA/CEPA between two trading partners. At this stage, the negotiating countries identify certain products for tariff liberalization pending the conclusion of actual FTA negotiations. Thus, it is only a step towards enhanced engagement and confidence building, making it the least comprehensive arrangement.
- **(1) Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA):** PTA is an agreement in which two or more partners give preferential right of entry to certain products. This is done by reducing duties on an agreed number of tariff lines. A positive list is maintained, i.e., only the listed products receive preferential access.
- **(3) Free Trade Agreement (FTA):** Partner countries provide wide-ranging tariff concessions and preferential trade terms. It generally uses a negative list approach, meaning tariffs are removed on most goods except those specifically excluded. Hence, FTA is more comprehensive than PTA.
- **(2) Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA):** Goes beyond trade in goods and covers services, investment, regulatory cooperation, customs cooperation, competition policy, and intellectual property rights (IPR).

Subject: International Relations || Trade arrangements

Question type: Analytical

Trinetra Approach

- **Name clue:** Early Harvest clearly signals a temporary preliminary step → least comprehensive.
- **Scope clue:** Preferential (PTA) means limited tariff concessions on selected products → next.
- **Depth clue:** Free Trade (FTA) removes tariffs on most goods (negative list) → broader.
- **Keyword clue:** Comprehensive in CEPA means widest coverage (goods, services, investment, regulations) → most comprehensive.

Extended Knowledge

- **Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement (CECA):** CECA generally cover negotiation on trade tariff and TQR rates only. It, however, is not as comprehensive as CEPA. India has signed CECA with Malaysia.
- **Customs Union:** A customs union is an agreement between two or more countries to remove trade barriers and lower or eliminate tariffs. Members of a customs union generally apply a common external tariff on imports from non-member countries.
- **Economic Union:** An economic union is an agreement between two or more nations to allow goods, services, money and workers to move over borders freely. The countries may also coordinate social and financial policies to support this common market. The European Union (EU) is an example of an economic union.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2236134>

63. Answer: D

Explanation:

- India's first indigenous drone defence dome called "Indrajaal" was designed and developed by Hyderabad-based technology R&D firm Grene Robotics. It has the capability to autonomously protect an area of 1000-2000 sq km against the aerial threats by assessing and acting on aerial threats such as Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs), loitering munitions, and Low- Radar Cross Section (RCS) targets.

Subject: Defence || Air defence system

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- **S-400 Triumf Missile System:** It is a mobile, surface-to-air missile system (SAM) designed by Russia. It is one of the most dangerous operationally deployed modern long-range SAM (MLR SAM) in the world, considered much ahead of the US-developed Terminal High Altitude Area Defense System (THAAD). The system can engage all types of aerial targets including aircraft, unmanned aerial vehicles (UAV) and ballistic and cruise missiles within a range of 400km, at an altitude of up to 30km.

- **Iron Dome:** It is Israel's air missile defense system that can defend against short-range rockets, intercepting them in the air above the state. It is a short-range mobile air defense system developed for Israel by Rafael Advanced Defense Systems and Israel Aerospace Industries.

🔗 **Further reading:** Read about Israel C-Dome

64. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is incorrect:** The International Conference on Financing for Development (FfD) is a UN-led platform organized roughly once every decade (e.g., Monterrey 2002, Doha 2008/2009, Addis Ababa 2015, Sevilla 2025).
- **Statement 2 is correct:** It is jointly supported by the UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UNDESA) and the UN Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC).
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The Sevilla Commitment is a comprehensive framework developed & adopted during the FfD4 conference, aiming to close the USD 4 trillion annual SDG financing gap in developing countries. The Sevilla Platform for Action, comprising 130 initiatives, serves as the implementation mechanism of the Sevilla Commitment.

Subject: International Relations | Organizations

Question type: Factual

Relevance: Fourth International Financing for Development Conference (FfD4) organized in Seville, Spain.

Extended Knowledge

- **Key Features of Fourth International Financing for Development Conference (FfD4)**
 - **Multi-Stakeholder Engagement:** Includes governments, multilateral institutions, civil society, and think tanks.
 - **Reform-Oriented Agenda:** Focuses on restructuring Multilateral Development Banks (MDBs) and addressing systemic issues like debt, taxation, and accountability.
 - **Integration with Climate Agendas:** Lays the groundwork for coordinated actions leading up to COP30.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.downtoearth.org.in/climate-change/ffd4-seville-what-are-the-links-to-the-climate-talks-and-the-road-from-seville-to-cop30-at-belem>

65. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Pradhan Mantri Virasat Ka Samvardhan (PM-VIKAS) is a Central Sector Scheme implemented by the Ministry of Minority Affairs. It is an integrated scheme that converges five erstwhile schemes: Seekho aur Kamao, USTTAD, Hamari Dharohar, Nai Roshni, and Nai Manzil. The scheme focuses on the socio-economic empowerment of the six notified minority communities (Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, and Parsis) by focusing on skill development, entrepreneurship, and education support, specifically targeting the preservation of traditional arts and crafts.

Subject: Government Schemes

Question type: Factual, Current affairs

Extended Knowledge

- **Scheme for Residential Education for Students in High Schools in Targeted Areas (SHRESHTA):** Launched in 2021 by the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment. It is a scholarship scheme to provide quality education and opportunities for the poorest Scheduled Caste students in CBSE-affiliated residential schools.
- **Pradhan Mantri Jan Vikas Karyakram (PMJVK):** The Central Government renamed and restructured the Multi-sectoral Development Programme (MsDP) as Pradhan Mantri Jan Vikas Karyakram (PMJVK). It aims to develop socio-economic and basic amenities assets like school, college, polytechnic, girls hostel, ITI, skill development centre etc for the minority communities.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2222788®=3&lang=2>

66. Answer: A

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organization (WAICO) was proposed by China as a multilateral body at APEC meeting 2025 in South Korea. It was announced during the World Artificial Intelligence Conference (2025) in Shanghai, China.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** WAICO aims to establish global AI governance norms, emphasizing human-centric design, data sovereignty, and algorithmic transparency, drawing from China's 2023 Global AI Governance Initiative.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** A key goal of the organization is to provide resources and institutional support for developing countries in the Global South for AI deployment and regulation.

Subject: International Relations || Organizations

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- **Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC)**
 - Founded in 1989
 - **Agenda:** Promote regional economic integration and greater prosperity in the Asia-Pacific region
 - **Members (21):** Australia, Brunei, New Zealand, Papua New Guinea, Hong Kong (as part of China), Philippines, Indonesia, Malaysia, Vietnam, Singapore, Thailand, Chinese Taipei (Taiwan), China, Japan, South Korea, Russia, Canada, USA, Mexico, Peru, Chile.
 - Membership criterion: Each member must be an independent economic entity, NOT necessarily a sovereign state.
 - **India:** NOT a member + India has applied for membership + Currently has observer status.
 - **Meeting/ Chairmanship:** ASEAN member chairs APEC every alternate year under the annual chairmanship rotation.

🔗 **Further reading:** Various initiatives for AI Governance- AI Seoul Summit, Bletchley declaration and India AI Summit.

67. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Global Peace Index, 2025 is released by the Institute for Economics and Peace (IEP). It covers 163 countries using 23 indicators. It compares deterioration in the average global level of peacefulness to previous years.
 - Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region: Remains the least peaceful
 - South Asia: 2nd least peaceful region in the world; experienced the largest regional decline in peacefulness.

Subject: International Reports

Question type: Factual

Trinetra Approach

- MENA has persistent conflicts (Yemen, Israel–Palestine), so it is logically the least peaceful region → Pair 1 likely correct.
- South Asia includes Afghanistan and Pakistan, historically among the least peaceful countries → Pair 2 plausible.
- Europe contains many stable countries (Nordic states, Western Europe), so it is unlikely to show the largest decline.
- Hence Pairs 1 & 2 correct, 3 incorrect → Answer: (b) Only two.

Extended Knowledge

- **Global Peace Index**
 - It assesses on 3 key domains: Societal safety and security, Ongoing domestic and international conflict, and Degree of militarisation
 - It compares deterioration in the average global level of peacefulness to previous years.
 - **India's rank:** 115th/163 (up from 116th in 2024)
 - **Global:**
 - Top position: Iceland (for the 17th consecutive year)
 - Bottom: Russia (163rd)

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://indianexpress.com/article/upsc-current-affairs/upsc-essentials/knowledge-nugget-global-peace-index-2025-terrorism-index-upsc-10078551/>

68. Answer: C

Explanation:

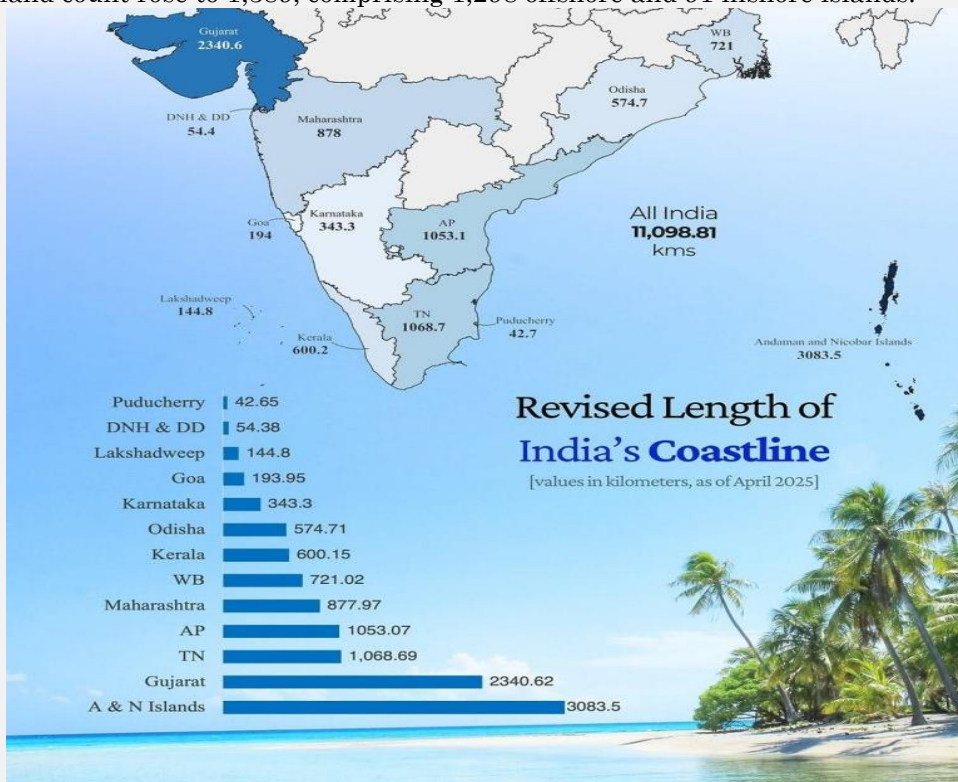
- The Coastline Paradox, explained by Lewis Fry Richardson, states that the measured length of a coastline depends on the scale or resolution of measurement. As the measuring unit becomes smaller, more indentations, curves, and irregularities are captured, causing the calculated length to increase indefinitely rather than converge to a fixed value.

Subject: Geography | Terminology in News

Question type: Conceptual

Extended Knowledge

- The Ministry of Home Affairs, in its 2023–24 report, updated India's coastline length to 11,099 km, up from 7,516.6 km.
- The total island count rose to 1,389, comprising 1,298 offshore and 91 inshore islands.



Further reading: <https://indianexpress.com/article/explained/india-coastline-island-10078625/>

69. Answer: C

Explanation:

- As per the Mines and Mineral (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957 (MMDR Act, 1957), “minor minerals” means building stones, gravel, ordinary clay, ordinary sand other than sand used for prescribed purposes, and any other mineral which the Central Government may, by notification in the Official Gazette, declare to be a minor mineral. State Governments have complete powers for making rules for grant of concessions in respect of extraction of minor minerals and levy and collection of royalty on minor minerals.

Subject: Miscellaneous | Major & Minor Minerals

Question type: Factual, Analytical

Relevance: Ministry of Mines Classifies Limestone as Major Mineral Completely (Oct 2025)

Extended Knowledge

- Major minerals are those specified in the first schedule appended in the MMDR Act. There is no official definition for “major minerals” in the MMDR Act, 1957. Hence, whatever is not declared as a “minor mineral” may be treated as the major mineral. Examples of major minerals include coal, manganese ore, iron ore, bauxite, limestone, kyanite, sillimanite, baryte and chromite.

Further reading: <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2179064®=3&lang=2>

70. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The Lambada tribe, also known as Sugalis or Banjaras, is one of the Scheduled Tribe communities primarily found in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh. They are believed to have originated from the Marwar region of Rajasthan. Traditionally, the Lambadas were semi-nomadic traders who transported goods across regions using bullock caravans. However, with the advent of British rule and the expansion of railways, this occupation gradually declined, forcing them to settle. They speak “Gor Boli” (Lambadi) and are culturally known for their distinctive attire, vibrant embroidery, and rich folk traditions, including traditional music performed with the ‘Dappan’ drum.

Subject: Tribes in news

Question type: Factual

Relevance: <https://www.downtoearth.org.in/governance/can-the-decades-old-constitutional-dispute-over-lambadas-scheduled-tribe-status-in-telangana-be-resolved>

Extended Knowledge

• **Bhil tribe**

- The Bhils are among the oldest tribal communities in India, belonging to the Austroloid group and often identified with the Dravidian racial stock of Western India. Known as skilled archers, their name derives from the Dravidian word billu/villu (bow).
- Traditionally spread across Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, and parts of Bihar. Present population pockets also exist in Tripura, Chhattisgarh, and Jharkhand.

🔗 **Further reading:** Gond and Soliga tribe

71. Answer: B

Explanation:

- NPS Vatsalya Scheme, 2025 announced in Budget 2024-25 is a Centrally Sponsored Scheme which aims to create pension savings for minors. It is an extension of the National Pension System (NPS).
- Statement 1 is correct:** The scheme is specifically designed for minor subscribers (below 18 years). Eligibility extends to minor Indian citizens, including Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) and Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs).
- Statement 2 is not correct:** Under the scheme, the minimum contribution is ₹250. There is no upper limit on the contribution amount. The lower contribution threshold is intended to make the scheme accessible and inclusive, encouraging long-term retirement savings from childhood.
- Statement 3 is correct:** Since the beneficiary is a minor, the guardian operates the account. When the subscriber turns 18, the account automatically transitions into a standard NPS account. At this stage, the subscriber gains full control of the account and continues contributions as a regular NPS subscriber.

Subject: Social Security | | Schemes

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

• **Other features of scheme**

- Pension payable after 60 years
- Permanent Retirement Account Number (PRAN) cards will be issued to newly registered minor subscribers
- On subscriber death → corpus to nominee
- Contribution is exempted from tax

🔗 **Further reading:** NPS Swasthya Pension Scheme (NSPS)

72. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Pact for Future is the most wide-ranging international agreement covering entirely new areas and issues on which agreement has not been possible in decades.
- Statement 1 is incorrect:** The Pact for the Future was not adopted at a UN Climate Change Conference (COP). It was adopted at the Summit of the Future held in New York in September 2024.
- Statement 2 is correct:** The Pact aims to strengthen global cooperation and accelerate progress on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). The Pact covers a broad range of issues including peace and security, sustainable development, climate change, digital cooperation, human rights, gender, youth and future generations, and the transformation of global governance.

- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Pact was not adopted only by developing countries. It was adopted by UN Member States collectively, reaffirming commitment to a UN-centred international system.

Subject: International Agreements

Question type: Analytical

Trinetra Approach

- Statement 3 uses the extreme word “only developing countries”, which is unlikely for a UN agreement → Incorrect.
- Statement 1 links the pact to a COP climate conference, but COPs deal mainly with climate agreements → Likely incorrect.
- Statement 2 uses common UN language about accelerating SDG progress, which is plausible → Correct.

Extended Knowledge

- The Pact for the Future includes a Global Digital Compact and a Declaration on Future Generations.
- Its adoption demonstrates that countries are committed to an international system with the United Nations at its centre.
- India has reiterated its firm support for the Pact for the Future and its key annexes- the Global Digital Compact and the Declaration on Future Generations- during the third informal dialogue to review the agreement.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.newsonair.gov.in/india-reaffirms-commitment-to-pact-for-future-at-un-dialogue/>

73. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Plausible deniability refers to a situation where a state conducts secret operations indirectly so that it can deny official involvement if exposed. It is typically linked with covert intelligence operations, proxy groups, or clandestine missions carried out by intelligence agencies. The strategy allows governments to avoid diplomatic, legal, or military consequences by maintaining uncertainty about their role.

Subject: Internal Security

Question type: Conceptual

Trinetra Approach

- “Deniability” means the state must be able to deny responsibility if questioned.
- In nuclear deterrence and conventional warfare, the actor must be clearly identifiable for deterrence and legality → reject (a) and (c).
- UN peacekeeping is official, multilateral, and documented → impossible to deny → reject (d).
- Only covert operations using proxies allow a state to act indirectly while denying involvement → (b).

Extended Knowledge

- Grey zone warfare: Actions below the threshold of open war. Includes economic coercion, cyber attacks, maritime militias. Objective: achieve strategic gains without triggering war.

🔗 **Further reading:** Read about Cold Start doctrine, Credible Minimum deterrence

74. Answer: D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Bharat NCX 2025 is conducted by the National Security Council Secretariat (NSCS) in collaboration with Rashtriya Raksha University (RRU).
- **Statement 2 is correct:** It aims to strengthen cyber resilience through real-world cyberattack simulations, including critical infrastructure breaches, deepfakes, and AI-driven malware.

Subject: Defence exercises

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- The 2025 theme — “Enhancing the Operational Preparedness of Indian Cyberspace” — directly indicates improving India’s readiness in cyberspace.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2146338>

75. Answer: B

Explanation:

- India is hosting its first national multi-sport event for tribal athletes, Khelo India Tribal Games in Chhattisgarh (Raipur, Jagdalpur and Surguja), bringing tribal athletes from across the country onto a national platform. The games are jointly organised by the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, SAI, IOA, National Sports Federations and the Chhattisgarh government, with international-level technical standards.
- Statement 1 is correct:** The Khelo India Tribal Games (2026) include seven medal sports—athletics, football, hockey, weightlifting, archery, swimming and wrestling—along with indigenous sports like kabaddi and mallakhamb.
- Statement 2 is incorrect:** Athlete selection follows a two-stage process: state/UT trials followed by national-level trials by sports federations, ensuring merit-based participation. A dedicated Talent Identification and Development Committee (TIDC) scouts promising athletes for further training under the Khelo India framework.
- Statement 3 is correct:** The official mascot, Morveer, reflects the spirit of the Games. Derived from the Chhattisgarhi words 'Mor' (our own) and 'Veer' (bravery), it symbolises pride, spirit and the identity of India's tribal communities.

Subject: Sports in news

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- Kabaddi** is one of India's oldest indigenous sports, with a history rooted in the Indian subcontinent where it was traditionally played as a test of strength, strategy and endurance. The sport gained international visibility when it was showcased at the 1936 Berlin Olympics as a demonstration event, marking one of its earliest appearances on a global platform.
- Mallakhamb** is a traditional Indian sport that combines elements of gymnastics, yoga and strength training, performed on a vertical wooden pole, rope or hanging apparatus. The name itself comes from 'malla' (wrestler) and 'khamb' (pole), reflecting its origins as a training practice for wrestlers.

Further reading: Khelo India programme

76. Answer: D

Explanation:

- Biological Weapons Convention is a legally binding international treaty that bans the use of biological and toxin weapons and prohibits all development, production, acquisition, stockpiling, or transfer of such weapons.
- Statement 1 is correct:** The Biological Weapons Convention (BWC), 1972 was the first international treaty to completely ban an entire category of weapons of mass destruction (biological and toxin weapons). It prohibits development, production, acquisition, transfer, stockpiling, and use of such weapons.
- Statement 2 is correct:** The BWC entered into force on March 26, 1975. This was decades before the Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC), which entered into force on April 29, 1997.
- Statement 3 is correct:** Under Article VI of the BWC, a State Party can lodge a complaint with the United Nations Security Council if it believes another state is violating the convention. The UNSC may initiate an investigation.

Subject: International agreements

Question type: Analytical

Relevance: 50 years of Biological weapons convention

Extended Knowledge

- Membership of BWC**
 - It currently has 187 states-parties, including Palestine, and four signatories (Egypt, Haiti, Somalia, and Syria).
 - Ten states have neither signed nor ratified the BWC (Chad, Comoros, Djibouti, Eritrea, Israel, Kiribati, Micronesia, Namibia, South Sudan, and Tuvalu).
 - India signed and ratified the BWC in 1974.

Further reading: Governance and Implementation of BWC

77. Answer: D

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** Notifiable diseases is any disease that is required to be reported legally to government authorities. It becomes legally binding (failure amount to a criminal offense) for a medical practitioner or its institutes to report cases of the disease to the government.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** As Health is a State subject (under List II), only the State Governments have powers to declare notified diseases.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** Examples of notified diseases in India include AIDS, Hepatitis B, Dengue Fever, Malaria, Whooping cough, Anaemia, Measles, Rabies, Vitamin A deficiency, typhoid, scarlet fever, polio, cerebro spinal fever, leprosy, Cholera, Iodine deficiency, malnutrition, tuberculosis, smallpox, plague, measles, influenza, diphtheria, chicken pox, etc.

Subject: Diseases in news

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Cancer is NOT a notifiable disease though the Parliamentary standing committee on health and family welfare suggested in its report.
- The World Organisation for Animal Health (WOAH), formerly the Office International des Epizooties (OIE) maintains a list of notified diseases for animals.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.thehindu.com/opinion/op-ed/should-cancer-be-a-notifiable-disease/article69336747.ece>

78. Answer: C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Red Fort was completed in 1648 by the Mughal emperor Shah Jahan as the palace fort of his new capital Shahjahanabad.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The fort complex contains the water channel Nahr-i-Behisht (Stream of Paradise) that flowed through the imperial pavilions.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The Red Fort appears on the ₹500 note of the Mahatma Gandhi (New Series), not on the ₹200 note.
- **Statement 4 is correct:** It was declared a World Heritage Site in 2007 by UNESCO.

Subject: Art and Culture || Current Affairs

Question type: Factual

Relevance: Red fort attacks

Extended Knowledge

• **Red Fort**

- Red Fort is located in Delhi along the banks of the Yamuna River
- Architectural Features: Built using red sandstone with a blend of Timurid and Persian architectural styles
- Architects: Designed by Ustad Ahmad Lahauri and Ustad Hamid
- Played a key role during the Indian Rebellion of 1857, when Bahadur Shah Zafar was declared leader. Later served as the venue for the INA Trials in the 1940s

🔗 **Further reading:** Features of Mughal Architecture

79. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **Statement-I is correct:** The World Food Prize, instituted in 1986 by Norman E. Borlaug, is widely regarded as the “Nobel Prize for Food and Agriculture.”
- **Statement-II is correct:** The prize recognises individuals who make outstanding contributions to improving the quality, quantity, or availability of food globally.
- **However, Statement-II does not explain Statement-I:** The description “Nobel Prize for Food and Agriculture” reflects the prestige and global stature of the award, not merely the objective mentioned in Statement-II.

Subject: Awards in News

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

• World Food Prize

- Instituted in 1986 by Norman E. Borlaug (1970 Nobel Peace Prize laureate; Father of the Green Revolution).
- Organised by World Food Prize Foundation (Headquarters: Des Moines, Iowa, USA).
- **Eligibility:** Open to individuals of any nationality, race, religion, or political belief.
- Awarded annually in October, around UN World Food Day (16 October).
- Brazilian microbiologist Mariangela Hungria was awarded the World Food Prize 2025 for her research on the interaction between soil bacteria and plant roots that enables biological nitrogen fixation.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.thehindu.com/sci-tech/energy-and-environment/world-food-prize-for-scientist-for-growing-food-with-fewer-chemicals/article69574892.ece>

80. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The Strait of Hormuz is a narrow but strategically vital waterway that serves as the primary maritime passage for oil and gas exports from the Persian Gulf to global markets. It lies between Iran (north) and Oman (south). It connects the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea, opening into the wider Indian Ocean.



Subject: International Relations || Mapping

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

• Key Facts of Strait of Hormuz

- About 20% of global oil supply (over 20 million barrels per day) transits this route.
- Nearly all of Qatar's LNG exports pass through the strait.
- Second-busiest oil transit chokepoint after the Strait of Malacca.

🔗 **Further reading:** https://www.business-standard.com/world-news/what-is-strait-of-hormuz-iran-israel-conflict-war-global-oil-trade-supply-126030200176_1.html

81. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari (JSJB) initiative is a flagship program under the Ministry of Jal Shakti. To strengthen urban water conservation, the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) partnered with the Ministry of Jal Shakti to motivate Urban Local Bodies to construct recharge structures.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The core objective of the awards is to promote public participation (Jan Bhagidari) and Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) involvement. It focuses on building, rejuvenating, and maintaining artificial recharge and storage structures such as borewell recharge systems and rooftop rainwater harvesting units.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** The awards are not only honorary and do include a significant cash component. Top-performing districts are awarded ₹2 crore (Category 1), while others receive ₹1 crore (Category 2) or ₹25 lakh (Category 3). These incentive amounts must be reinvested into further water conservation activities.

Subject: Government Schemes

Question type: Factual

Relevance: Recently, the President of India conferred the first Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari (JSJB) Awards 2025.

Extended Knowledge

• Jal Sanchay Jan Bhagidari Awards

- Launched in 2024 at Surat, Gujarat | Community-driven initiative under the Jal Shakti Abhiyan: Catch the Rain campaign
- **Target:** Districts encouraged to construct 10,000 recharge structures (3,000 for hilly and Northeast districts).
- **Top States (2025):** Telangana (1st), Chhattisgarh (2nd), Rajasthan (3rd).

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2188706®=3&lang=2>

82. Answer: B

Explanation:

- World Boxing Championships 2025 is a premier international amateur boxing championship featuring top boxers from around the world. It is organised under the Global boxing governing system for amateur boxing competitions.
- **Statement 1 is correct:** The 2025 Championships in Liverpool marked the first time that both men's and women's events were held together in a single championship.
- **Statement 2 is not correct:** The overall medal table was topped by Kazakhstan. India won 4 medals but did not lead the standings.
- **Statement 3 is correct:** The championship was indeed held at the Liverpool Arena in Liverpool, United Kingdom.

Subject: Sports in news

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- India's Performance: Won a total 4 medals
 - Jaismine Lamboria – Gold medal (57 kg category)
 - Minakshi Hooda – Gold medal (48 kg category)
 - Nupur Sheoran – Silver medal
 - Pooja Rani – Bronze medal

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.olympics.com/en/news/world-boxing-championships-2025-india-medal-winners-champions>

83. Answer: B

Explanation:

- The Total Fertility Rate (TFR) is the average number of children a woman is expected to have during her reproductive lifetime. The replacement-level fertility (~2.1 children per woman) is the level required for a population to replace itself from one generation to the next in the absence of migration. When TFR falls below the replacement level, each generation of women produces fewer daughters than required to replace itself, implying insufficient net reproduction for long-term generational replacement.

Subject: Economic & Social Development || Demographics

Question type: Conceptual

Trinetra Approach

- “Replacement level” means a generation replaces itself. So below replacement → fewer people in the next generation.
- **(a) Eliminate:** Words like “immediately” and “irrespective of migration” are extreme.
- **(c) Eliminate:** TFR (lifetime fertility) ≠ CBR/CDR (annual rates); one does not automatically determine the other in the same year.
- **(d) Eliminate:** Stage I has high fertility, opposite of below-replacement fertility.
- **Thus (b) fits the logic:** If fertility is below replacement, generations cannot fully replace themselves without migration.

Extended Knowledge

- Sample Registration System (SRS) statistical report, 2023

- **National Level:** The TFR for India in 2023 is 1.9. 18 States and UTs had reported a TFR of below the replacement level TFR of 2.1.
- **Rural vs. Urban:** The TFR in rural areas is 2.1, while in urban areas it is 1.5. This is the first time that TFR in rural India has touched replacement rate.
- **Highest TFR:** Bihar (2.8); **Lowest TFR:** Delhi (1.2)

🔗 **Further reading:** General Fertility rate

84. Answer: B

Explanation:

- PM RAHAT Scheme is an initiative of the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways to provide immediate, cashless treatment to road accident victims. It focuses on timely medical care, as nearly 50% of road accident deaths can be prevented if victims receive hospital treatment within the Golden Hour (the first hour after a serious injury).
- It operates through a technology-driven framework that creates a seamless digital link from accident reporting to claim settlement, combining:
 - **Electronic Detailed Accident Report (eDAR) platform** (from the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways).
 - **Transaction Management System (TMS 2.0)** of the National Health Authority.

Subject: Social Sector Initiatives

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- **Features of PM RAHAT Scheme**
 - **Cashless Treatment and Coverage:** Victims on any road (e.g., national highways, state roads, and city streets) are entitled to cashless treatment up to Rs 1.5 lakh per victim for the first 7 days.
 - **Funding Mechanism:** Hospitals will be reimbursed through the Motor Vehicle Accident Fund (MVAFF). If the offending vehicle is insured, payment will be made from contributions by General Insurance Companies.
 - **Emergency Response Integration:** The scheme is integrated with the Emergency Response Support System (ERSS) dial 112, allowing any individual (victim or Good Samaritan) to request ambulance services and locate the nearest designated hospital.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2228172®=3&lang=2>

85. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Good Governance Day is observed annually on December 25, the birth anniversary of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee, whose leadership emphasised accountability, transparency, and inclusive growth. The day reminds us that governance is not just about administration, but about making life better for every citizen. It was designated by the Government of India in 2014.

Subject: Governance

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- Theme (2025): "Prashasan Gaon Ki Ore" — Governance Towards Villages
- **Note:** Good Governance Index (GGI) was formally introduced on December 25, 2019

🔗 **Further reading:** Good Governance Index

<https://www.pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=2208145®=3&lang=1>

86. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Purple Notice is one of the eight colour-coded notices issued by the International Criminal Police Organization (INTERPOL). Its purpose is to share information about criminals' modus operandi, objects, devices, and concealment methods.
- **Situation 1 (Concealment techniques in narcotics trafficking):** Fits the Purple Notice as it involves a new "concealment method" and "modus operandi".

- **Situation 2 (Provisional arrest of a fugitive):** This would require a Red Notice, which is used to seek the location and arrest of persons wanted for prosecution or to serve a sentence.
- **Situation 3 (Suspicious device in ATM skimming):** Fits the Purple Notice as it involves sharing information about specific "devices" and "modus operandi" used across multiple countries.

Subject: International Relations | Organizations

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- **Interpol**

- The International Criminal Police Organization (INTERPOL), commonly known as Interpol, is an international organization facilitating international police cooperation against cross-border terrorism, trafficking, and other crime.
- It is the world's largest international police organization, representing 195 member countries.
- It is headquartered in Lyon, France.
- It is 'not' a unit or part of a united nation system. It is an independent international organization.

🔍 **Further reading:** Governance structure of Interpol

87. Answer: C

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** The term "Biohappiness" was coined by M. S. Swaminathan, the agricultural scientist and founder of the M. S. Swaminathan Research Foundation (MSSRF). The concept refers to a state of well-being and fulfilment arising from conserving and sustainably using biodiversity, linking ecological conservation with human welfare.
- **Option B is correct:** Biohappiness emphasises human well-being through biodiversity conservation, including:
 - Health (diverse and nutritious diets)
 - Nutrition security
 - Sustainable livelihoods (biodiversity-based livelihoods for communities)
 - Ecological harmony (maintaining balance between humans and nature).
- **Option C is not correct:** Biohappiness does not measure economic prosperity or industrial output derived from biodiversity. It is a well-being and sustainability concept, focusing on quality of life, ecological balance and community livelihoods, rather than industrial production or GDP-type indicators.
- **Option D is correct:** Keyi Panyor district in Arunachal Pradesh has been declared India's first "Bio-Happy District."

Subject: Environment | Terms in news

Question type: Factual, Analytical

Trinetra Approach

- In environment questions, concepts like "Biohappiness" usually relate to sustainability and well-being, not industrial production metrics.
- (a) and (b) both consistently link biodiversity with well-being, health, nutrition and ecology, so they reinforce the same theme.
- (d) is a place-based initiative, which governments often launch to promote such concepts (similar to eco-villages, biodiversity districts).
- (c) introduces "economic prosperity through industrial production", which shifts the concept from well-being → GDP-style measurement, making it logically inconsistent → incorrect.

🔍 **Further reading:** <https://www.thehindu.com/opinion/op-ed/aiming-for-an-era-of-biohappiness-in-india/article69657847.ece>

88. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Emblems and Names (Prevention of Improper Use) Act, 1950 is a regulatory legislation to prevent the commercial or improper use of national emblems, names, and symbols that hold public significance or represent national institutions. It prohibits misuse of names/emblems associated with national institutions or public trust.
- **Statement 1 is correct:** Section 3 of the Act prohibits the use of specified names and emblems for professional, commercial, trade or advertising purposes without prior permission of the Central Government.

- **Statement 2 is correct:** The Schedule to the Act specifically lists protected items, including the Indian National Flag (Item 3) and the name or pictorial representation of Mahatma Gandhi (Item 9A), Rashtrapati Bhavan, and others.
- **Statement 3 is not correct:** The Act extends to the whole of India and also applies to Indian citizens outside India. Therefore, it is not limited only to the territory of India.

Subject: Polity || Basics

Question type: Analytical

Relevance: SC dismisses plea to clarify 'facts', protect Savarkar's name under Emblems Act

Trinetra Approach

- Statement-1: Acts named "Prevention of Improper Use" usually restrict commercial misuse → sounds reasonable → likely correct.
- Statement-3: Saying a law applies only inside India and not to Indian citizens abroad is too absolute; many Indian laws have extra-territorial scope → suspicious → likely incorrect.

Extended Knowledge

Emblems and Names (Prevention of Improper Use) Act, 1950

- Ban on Registrations (Section 4): Authorities cannot register companies, trademarks, or patents bearing protected names/emblems.
- Penalty (Section 5): Misuse punishable by fine up to ₹500.
- Mandatory Sanction (Section 6): Prior sanction from the Centre is needed before prosecution.

Further

reading:

[https://epaper.thehindu.com/ccidist-
ws/th/th_international/issues/133572/OPS/GL7ED8VI9.1+GEOEEA270.1.html](https://epaper.thehindu.com/ccidist-
ws/th/th_international/issues/133572/OPS/GL7ED8VI9.1+GEOEEA270.1.html)

89. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Article 51A(a) STATES THAT EVERY CITIZEN SHALL ABIDE BY THE CONSTITUTION AND RESPECT ITS IDEALS AND INSTITUTIONS, THE NATIONAL FLAG AND THE NATIONAL ANTHEM. HOWEVER, NATIONAL SONG (VANDE MATARAM) IS NOT INCLUDED IN THIS DUTY.

Article 51A of Indian Constitution

PART IVA

FUNDAMENTAL DUTIES

51A. Fundamental duties.—It shall be the duty of every citizen of India—

- (a) to abide by the Constitution and respect its ideals and institutions, the National Flag and the National Anthem;
- (b) to cherish and follow the noble ideals which inspired our national struggle for freedom;
- (c) to uphold and protect the sovereignty, unity and integrity of India;
- (d) to defend the country and render national service when called upon to do so;
- (e) to promote harmony and the spirit of common brotherhood amongst all the people of India transcending religious, linguistic and regional or sectional diversities; to renounce practices derogatory to the dignity of women;
- (f) to value and preserve the rich heritage of our composite culture;
- (g) to protect and improve the natural environment including forests, lakes, rivers and wild life, and to have compassion for living creatures;
- (h) to develop the scientific temper, humanism and the spirit of inquiry and reform;
- (i) to safeguard public property and to abjure violence;
- (j) to strive towards excellence in all spheres of individual and collective activity so that the nation constantly rises to higher levels of endeavour and achievement;
- (k) who is a parent or guardian to provide opportunities for education to his child or, as the case may be, ward between the age of six and fourteen years.

Subject: Polity || Current Affairs

Question type: Analytical

Relevance: 150 years of National Song

Extended Knowledge

- The Constituent Assembly of India adopted “Vande Mataram” as a national song on 24 January 1950.
- **Origins and References:** Written by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay and featured in his novel Anand Math (1882)
 - Anand Math was inspired by the Sanyasi Rebellion of the late 18th century and the rebellion of 1857
 - Recited by Rabindranath Tagore in 1896 at the annual session of the Indian National Congress
 - It is a poetic identification written in Bengali and Sanskrit
 - In 1937, the Indian National Congress adopted its first two stanzas as the National Song

🔍 **Further reading:** <https://www.thehindu.com/opinion/lead/vande-mataram-its-six-stanzas-and-a-settled-question/article70625006.ece>

90. Answer: A

Explanation:

- India's 500 MWe Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) at Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu, achieved its first criticality on April 6, 2026, marking a major milestone in Stage-2 of India's nuclear program. Operated by Bharatiya Nabhikiya Vidyut Nigam Limited (BHAVINI), this indigenous reactor uses uranium-plutonium mixed oxide fuel to breed more fissile material than it consumes.
- **Statement 1 is correct:** India's Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) is located at Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** Fast Breeder Reactors use fast neutrons to sustain nuclear fission, unlike conventional reactors that use thermal (slow) neutrons.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Criticality only means the reactor has achieved a self-sustaining chain reaction. It does not imply immediate electricity generation; further testing and commissioning are required before power production begins.

Subject: Current affairs | | Nuclear energy

Question type: Analytical

Trinetra Approach

- Statement 3 looks extreme — “immediately starts supplying electricity”; in technical processes, milestones rarely mean instant final output → likely incorrect.
- Hence eliminate options containing 3 → remove (b), (c), (d).
- Remaining option is (a) 1 and 2 only.

Extended Knowledge

- **Fast Breeder Reactor**
 - A Fast Breeder Reactor (FBR) is a type of nuclear reactor that generates more fissile material than it consumes.
 - FBRs typically use plutonium-based fuel, often in the form of Mixed Oxide (MOX), along with fertile materials such as uranium-238. These fertile materials are converted into fissile material (like plutonium-239) during reactor operation.
 - FBRs are crucial for countries like India that have limited uranium reserves but abundant thorium resources.

🔍 **Further reading:** India's three stage nuclear programme

91. Answer: A

Explanation:

- **Option A is correct:** Brent Crude is a high-quality light and "sweet" crude oil extracted from several fields in the North Sea. It serves as the leading global price benchmark, used to price approximately two-thirds of the world's internationally traded crude oil. It is the primary reference for oil produced in or exported to Europe, Africa, and the Middle East.
- **Option B is not correct:** While West Texas Intermediate (WTI) is a light crude benchmark used for pricing in North America, it is primarily traded on the New York Mercantile Exchange (NYMEX), not the Intercontinental Exchange (ICE). Brent Crude is the benchmark typically traded on the ICE.

- **Option C is not correct:** Dubai Fateh Crude is a medium crude benchmark primarily used to price oil exports from the Middle East to Asian markets, rather than Europe.
- **Option D is not correct:** OPEC Reference Basket is a weighted average of oils produced by OPEC members, but it is not the primary benchmark for global crude oil trade.

Subject: Current affairs | | Global oil market

Question type: Conceptual

Extended Knowledge

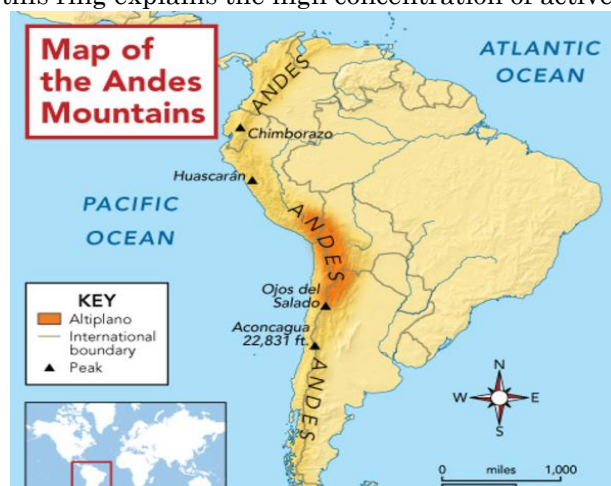
- **Oman Crude Oil Benchmark:** It is often used for pricing oil in the Middle East and parts of Asia. It is similar to Dubai crude, as both are sour crudes with a higher sulfur content. Oman crude is traded in the Asia-Pacific region, and it has become an important crude oil pricing benchmark for countries like China, Japan, and India.

🔦 **Further reading:** <https://www.thehindu.com/business/markets/crude-oil-futures-hit-record-10888barrel-wti-touches-116/article70833165.ece>

92. Answer: A

Explanation:

- **Statement-I is correct:** The Andes Mountains are a 5,500-mile-long range on the western coast of South America, known for having numerous active volcanoes (e.g., Ojos del Salado, Cotopaxi).
- **Statement-II is correct and explains Statement-I:** The Andes are formed as a result of the Nazca Plate (oceanic) subducting beneath the South American Plate (continental). This subduction causes melting in the mantle, creating magma that rises to form volcanoes.
- **Statement-III is correct and explains Statement-I:** The Andes are part of the Pacific Ring of Fire, a 40,000-km horseshoe-shaped zone of high tectonic activity that includes the western coast of South America. Being part of this ring explains the high concentration of active volcanoes.



Subject: Geography | | South America

Question type: Conceptual

Trinetra Approach

- Statement-II mentions a subduction zone, and subduction commonly produces volcanic arcs, so it logically explains why the Andes have many volcanoes → II likely correct.
- Statement-III says Andes are in the Pacific Ring of Fire, which is globally known for volcano concentration → III also likely correct.
- Since both II and III are consistent with volcanism, rejecting either would contradict well-known tectonic logic.

Extended Knowledge

- The Andes Mountains extend over seven countries: Argentina (Mount Aconcagua), Bolivia (Huayna Potosi), Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, and Venezuela, known as Andean States.
- It is about 5,500 miles (8,900 km) long and second only to the Himalayas in average elevation.
- The highest elevation in the Andes is Mount Aconcagua in Argentina, which is 22,841 feet (6,962 m) above sea level.

🔦 **Further reading:** Read about Rocky mountains

93. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Atmospheric memory refers to the retention of moisture (water vapour) from previous atmospheric conditions. This stored moisture can facilitate continued convection and precipitation once rainfall begins. Hence, after monsoon circulation is established, rainfall tends to persist due to existing humid conditions. Thus, atmospheric memory helps sustain active phases of the Indian monsoon.

Subject: Geography || Climatology

Question type: Conceptual

Extended Knowledge

Key Aspects of the Atmospheric Memory Mechanism

- Bistability: The system flips between two stable states—dry and wet—based on the amount of stored moisture rather than immediate solar heating.
- Impact of Warming: Rising temperatures increase evaporation and the atmosphere's capacity for water vapor (following the Clausius-Clapeyron relation), strengthening this memory effect and impacting the stability of monsoon systems in South Asia, South America, and Australia.

🔍 **Further reading:** <https://www.downtoearth.org.in/climate-change/monsoons-remember-to-switch-on-and-off-disrupting-it-could-be-dangerous-finds-study>

94. Answer: C

Explanation:

- Noctilucent ("night shining") clouds are thin, wispy clouds that glow with a blue or silvery light at night when lit by sunlight from below the horizon. They form in the mesosphere by ice crystals on dust particles (from micrometeorites, volcanic dust, or rocket exhausts) in very cold mesosphere. They appear only during summer months and between 45° to 80° latitude in both hemispheres. Sighting of these clouds are more common at higher latitudes where the Sun stays just below the horizon longer at night. They are the highest clouds on the Earth.

Subject: Geography || Climatology

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Lenticular clouds (Altostratus lenticularis) are stationary, lens-shaped clouds that form at high altitudes, usually near mountains, when stable, moist air flows over a ridge, creating standing waves. Known for their smooth, "spaceship" appearance, these clouds are formed by condensation in the wave crest and can indicate high turbulence for pilots.

🔍 **Further reading:** Cirrostratus and Mammatus clouds

95. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Kolleru Lake:** It is situated between the deltas of the Godavari and Krishna rivers in Andhra Pradesh. It was designated as a Ramsar Site on August 19, 2002. **Thus, it satisfies both the conditions.**
- Gogabeel Lake:** It is an oxbow lake located in the Katihar district of Bihar, positioned between the Ganga and Mahananda rivers. It was designated as India's 94th Ramsar Site in November 2025. **Thus, it satisfies both the conditions.**
- Kanwar Taal:** Located in Bihar, is a Ramsar Site (2020) and the largest freshwater oxbow lake of Asia. However, it was formed due to the meandering of the Gandak River and is not located between two major rivers. **Thus, it satisfies only Condition 2.**
- Wular Lake:** It is primarily fed and drained by a single major river, the Jhelum. It is not located between two major rivers. It was designated as a Ramsar Site in 1990. **Thus, it satisfies only Condition 1.**

Subject: Geography & Environment || Lakes

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Gogabeel Lake:** It is Bihar's first notified Community Reserve. Acts as a vital wintering ground for the Central Asian Flyway; managed and conserved by the local community.
- Wular Lake:** Largest freshwater lake in India

🔍 **Further reading:** Read about characteristics of Kolleru Lake

96. Answer: C

Explanation:

- **Statement 1 is correct:** The Prime Meridian (0° longitude) passing through the Royal Observatory at Greenwich, London is the internationally accepted reference line for measuring longitude. Longitudes are measured eastward and westward from 0° up to 180°, where the 180° meridian roughly corresponds to the International Date Line.
- **Statement 2 is correct:** When the Prime Meridian is traced southward into Africa, it passes through the countries: Algeria, Mali, Burkina Faso, Togo and Ghana.

Subject: Geography || Latitudes & Longitudes

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- Countries Passing Through Prime Meridian: United Kingdom, France, Spain, Algeria, Mali, Burkina Faso, Togo and Ghana.
- The Prime Meridian and 180° meridian divide the earth into two equal halves, the Eastern Hemisphere (E) and the Western Hemisphere (W).

🔗 **Further reading:** Important parallels of Latitude- Equator, Tropic of cancer and Capricorn

97. Answer: B

Explanation:

- “Wolf Moon” is the traditional name for the full moon occurring in January, widely referenced in North American and European folklore. The name is associated with the harsh mid-winter period, when wolves were believed to howl more frequently near human settlements during long, cold nights. The term draws from Indigenous, Celtic, and Old English traditions, which linked seasonal animal behaviour with lunar cycles.

Subject: Geography || Current affairs

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- **Wolf Supermoon**
 - A Wolf Supermoon is a combined term referring to the occurrence of the Wolf Moon at the time of a Supermoon.
 - A Supermoon occurs when the Moon reaches its closest point to the Earth at the same time that it is in its full phase, making it appear slightly larger and brighter in the night sky.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.thehindu.com/sci-tech/science/what-is-a-wolf-supermoon/article70470023.ece>

98. Answer: A

Explanation:

- Researchers from the University of Southern California analyzed seismic data and nuclear tests and provided “unambiguous evidence” of slowdown of earth inner core, sparking debate on core dynamics and Earth’s rotation.
- **Statement 1 is correct:** Studies show that when the inner core slows down (or speeds up), the angular momentum transfer to the mantle causes the surface to adjust its rotation speed, resulting in small variations in the length of a day (by fractions of a millisecond).
- **Statement 2 is correct:** The inner core’s rotation is crucial in generating Earth’s magnetic field, which shields the planet from harmful solar radiation and influences geological processes. Any changes in the inner core’s rotational speed could potentially impact Earth’s magnetic properties, possibly affecting geomagnetic events and natural conditions on the planet’s surface.
- **Statement 3 is incorrect:** Plate tectonics is driven by a combination of mantle convection, slab pull, and ridge push, powered by Earth’s internal heat. The inner core’s rotational variations do not directly trigger tectonic plate movements.

Subject: Geography || Composition of Earth

Question type: Analytical

Extended Knowledge

- **Earth’s Inner Core**
 - Located at the Earth’s center, approximately 5,150 kilometers (3,219 miles) beneath the Earth’s surface.
 - It is the innermost layer of the Earth. It is a hot iron ball of the size of Pluto.
 - The inner core is solid due to the pressure caused by the weight put on it by the Earth’s other top layers.

- Temperature between 7,200–8,500°F (4,000–4,700°C).
- It is predicted to have very high thermal and electrical conductivity.
- The boundary between the inner and outer cores is called the Lehman Seismic Discontinuity.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://www.downtoearth.org.in/science-technology/earths-inner-core-isnt-just-slowing-down-it-may-be-changing-shape>

99. Answer: B

Explanation:

- **Pair 1 is correct:** Benin is a country located in West Africa. It borders Togo to the west, Nigeria to the east, and Burkina Faso and Niger to the north.
- **Pair 2 is not correct:** The Kerem Shalom crossing is a primary border crossing located at the junction of Israel, the Gaza Strip, and Egypt. It is a critical point for the passage of goods and humanitarian aid into Gaza.
- **Pair 3 is not correct:** Socotra Island belongs to Yemen and lies in the Arabian Sea near the Gulf of Aden. It is usually considered part of the north-western Indian Ocean, not the central Indian Ocean.

Subject: Geography || Mapping

Question type: Factual

Extended Knowledge

- **Benin:** Navigating a tense security landscape following a thwarted military coup in December 2025, which saw President Patrice Talon retain power with Nigerian air force support. The nation faces rising threats from Islamic extremist groups, particularly in the northern border regions, while battling extreme poverty.
- **Kerem Shalom crossing:** Primary and often only operational entry point for cargo into the Gaza Strip.
- **Socotra Island:** The UAE and WHO have jointly launched a two-year humanitarian programme to tackle severe child and maternal malnutrition on Yemen's Socotra Island.

🔗 **Further reading:** <https://ddnews.gov.in/en/uae-partners-with-who-to-launch-two-year-initiative-targeting-child-malnutrition-crisis-on-yemens-socotra-island/>

100. Answer: B

Explanation:

- Chasms are narrow, deep recesses or indentations cut into sea cliffs. They are created by wave action focusing on vertical planes of weakness (joints, faults, or fractures) in the rocks, leading to intense headward erosion. Over time, wave action widens these narrow cracks laterally, transforming them into broader coastal indentations or bays.



Subject: Geography || Geomorphology

Question type: Conceptual

Extended Knowledge

- **Fjord:** A fjord is a long, deep, narrow body of water that reaches far inland. Fjords are often set in a U-shaped valley with steep walls of rock on either side. Fjords are found mainly in Norway, Chile, New Zealand, Canada, Greenland, and the U.S. state of Alaska.
- **Spits and hooks:** These are coastal depositional landforms formed by longshore drift. A spit is an elongated ridge of sand or shingle extending from the land into open water. A hook is a specialized, curved spit, created when the end bends inland due to shifting winds or currents.

🔗 **Further reading:** Read about Tomobolos